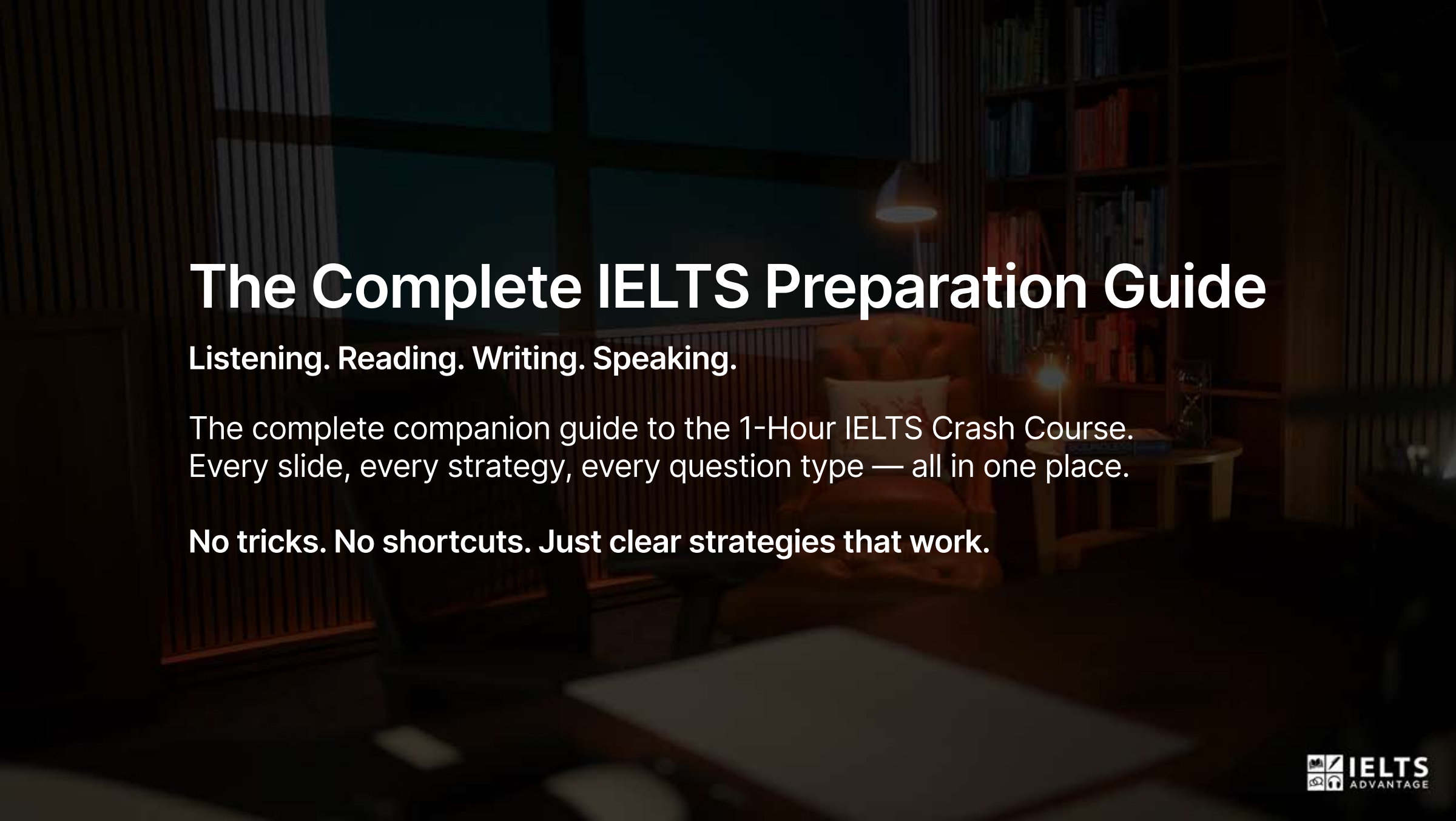


The Complete IELTS Preparation Guide

Listening. Reading. Writing. Speaking.

The complete companion guide to the 1-Hour IELTS Crash Course.
Every slide, every strategy, every question type — all in one place.

No tricks. No shortcuts. Just clear strategies that work.

IELTS ADVANTAGE

Table of Contents

LISTENING

01 **Listening Segment Slides** — 03
Key slides from the Crash Course listening segment

02 **The Complete A-to-Z Guide to IELTS Listening** — 26
Step-by-step strategies for all listening question types

READING

03 **Reading Segment Slides** — 66
Key slides from the Crash Course reading segment

04 **The Complete A-to-Z Guide to IELTS Reading** — 110
Step-by-step strategies for all reading question types

SPEAKING

05 **Speaking Segment Slides** — 152
Key slides from the Crash Course speaking segment

WRITING TASK 2

06 **Task 2 Segment Slides** — 176
Key slides from the Crash Course Writing Task 2 segment

07 **Task 2 Structures Guide** — 203
Proven essay structures for all Writing Task 2 question types

VOCABULARY

08 **Vocabulary Improvement Plan** — 230
A structured plan for finding, recording, and retaining new vocabulary

IELTS ADVANTAGE

IELTS Listening: What Successful Students Do Differently

Based on 10+ years working with thousands of Band 7, 8 & 9 students

TEST FORMAT

IELTS Listening Test Format

30 Minutes

Plus 10 minutes to transfer answers

4 Sections

40 questions total, progressively harder

One Chance

You hear each recording ONLY ONCE

10+ Question Types

Perfect spelling required throughout

Why Students Struggle

You must do all of these **AT THE SAME TIME**:

Read Questions

Quickly scan and understand what's being asked whilst staying focused

Listen Carefully

Catch every word and nuance without missing critical information

Write Answers

Record responses accurately with perfect spelling under pressure

Think & Predict

Anticipate what's coming next and identify synonyms on the fly

Manage Time

Keep pace without getting stuck on difficult questions

What Successful Students Know

> Focus on getting **100% in Sections 1, 2 & 3** first. Section 4's harder questions are designed to separate Band 8s from Band 9s.

Section 1

Master the basics

Section 2

Build confidence

Section 3

Secure your score

Section 4

Bonus points

Don't panic about hard questions when you should be securing easier ones. This strategic approach reduces stress and maximises your score potential.

GAME CHANGERS

3 Things Successful Students Do Differently

01

Listen Actively, Not Passively

02

Use Different Strategy for Each Question Type

03

Listen Just Once in Practice

#1

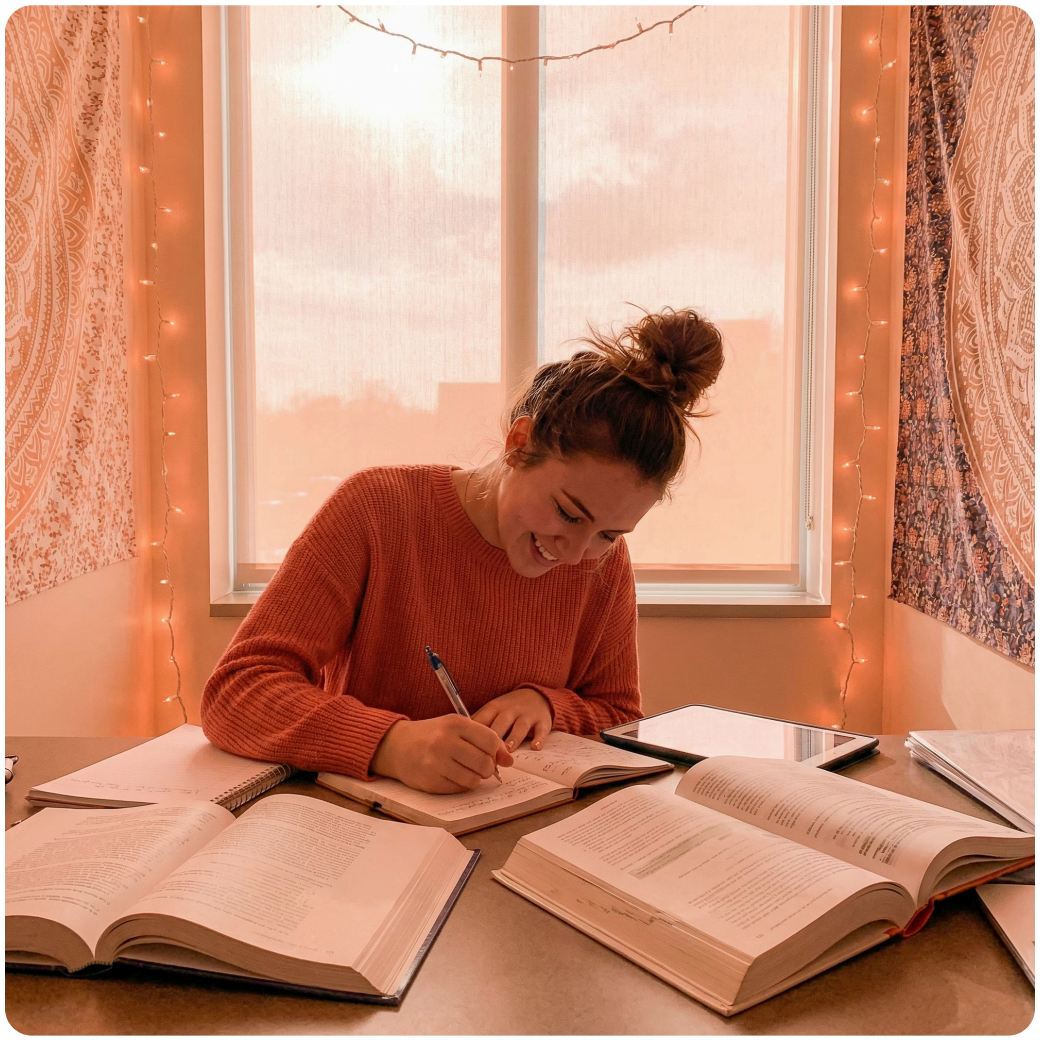
Listen Actively, Not Passively

Passive Listening ×

- Watching Netflix for entertainment
- Listening to music in the background
- Just trying to understand the general meaning
- No specific task or goal

Active Listening ✓

- Predicting answers before you hear them
- Looking for specific keywords
- Identifying synonyms and paraphrasing
- Writing whilst listening simultaneously
- Answering questions with purpose



Active Listening = Doing Something Whilst You Listen

Taking Notes During TED Talks

Write down key points, vocabulary, and main arguments as the speaker presents

Answering Questions During Podcasts

Create your own comprehension questions or use guided listening activities

Practising with IELTS Tests

Complete actual exam questions under realistic time constraints

Focusing on Specific Skills

Target vocabulary acquisition, synonym recognition, and spelling accuracy

#2

Different Strategy for Each Question Type

10+ Question Types = 10+ Different Strategies

Multiple Choice

Differentiating keywords and eliminating distractors

Form Completion

Predict word type and focus on specific information

Map Labelling

Signposting language and spatial visualisation

Sentence Completion

Grammar analysis and contextual prediction

Critical point: Using the same approach for everything = FAILURE. Each question type demands its own tactical approach.

You Wouldn't Use the Same Strategy for Every Sport

Football

Team coordination, positioning, passing strategies

Basketball

Fast breaks, zone defence, individual plays

Tennis

Serve and volley, baseline rallies, court coverage

> Different games = Different strategies
> Same principle applies to IELTS question types

#3

Listen Just Once in Practice

In English Class

- Listen 3–4 times ✓
- Feels comfortable ✓
- Builds false confidence ▒
- Doesn't reflect exam reality ▒

In Real Test

- Listen ONCE
- No rewind button
- No second chance
- No time to relax

"Train Hard, Fight Easy"

Make your practice sessions more challenging than the actual test, and exam day will feel manageable.

STRATEGY DEMO

Example: Multiple Choice Strategy

Let me show you what "different strategy" actually means in practice. We'll walk through a real IELTS question step by step.

1. See the Question
2. Learn the Strategy
3. Apply It

Sample Question

Here's an authentic IELTS multiple choice question. Take a moment to read both questions carefully.

Type of insurance chosen:

- A. Economy
- B. Standard
- C. Premium

Customer wants goods delivered to:

- A. Port
- B. Home
- C. Depot

Notice how each question has three options. Your task is to identify the correct answer whilst listening to the recording just once.

5-Step Strategy for Multiple Choice

Read Instructions Carefully

Check how many answers to choose and any specific requirements

Identify Differentiating Keywords

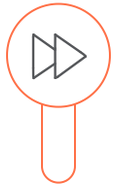
Find the words that make each option unique from the others

Think of Synonyms & Paraphrasing

The recording will use different words with the same meaning

Listen to the WHOLE Section

Don't jump to conclusions — the answer might come at the end



Keep Moving

If you miss one, move on immediately to avoid missing the next question

Step 2: Look at the Differences

Understanding the relationships between answer options helps you listen more strategically.

Economy & Standard

- Similar meaning
- Basic service level
- Lower cost options
- Minimal features

Premium

- Opposite meaning
- Higher service level
- Higher cost option
- Enhanced features

Notice how Economy and Standard are similar, whilst Premium stands apart. This pattern appears frequently in IELTS.

Step 3: Predict Synonyms

> They won't say "Premium" directly in the recording.

"First Class"

Suggests top tier

"VIP Service"

Implies exclusivity

"Highest Level"

Indicates superiority

"Most Expensive"

References cost

"Best Quality"

Emphasises excellence

"Top Package"

Suggests completeness

Training yourself to anticipate synonyms dramatically improves your listening accuracy. This skill separates Band 6 from Band 8 students.

IMPORTANT

This Is Just ONE Question Type

10+

Question Types

Each with unique characteristics

10+

Strategies

Specific approaches for each type

100%

Coverage

Complete system available

We've covered multiple choice in detail, but there are map labelling, form completion, sentence completion, matching, and many more. Each requires its own step-by-step strategy, all available in the full video linked below.

CRITICAL

The Biggest Problem

How You Practise Matters More Than What You Know

Knowing strategies ≠ Success

You must practise **CORRECTLY** to see real improvement. Most students sabotage their progress with poor practice habits.

What Most Students Do Wrong

1

Don't Practise at All

Hoping to improve through passive exposure alone

2

Use Fake YouTube Tests

Unrealistic questions that don't match actual exam format

3

Listen Multiple Times

Creating false confidence that collapses in the real test

4

Never Practise Under Exam Conditions

Taking breaks, checking answers, using notes and dictionaries

5

Don't Analyse Mistakes

Repeating the same errors without understanding why

⚠ WARNING

Problem: Fake Practice Tests

Why Fake Tests Damage Your Progress

❌ Too Easy

Don't reflect actual exam difficulty

❌ Nothing Like Real Test

Different format and question styles

❌ Misleading Questions

Train you for the wrong exam

❌ Wrong Format

Waste your valuable study time

Trusted Sources

- Official IELTS.org
- British Council
- IDP Education
- Cambridge English books

How Successful Students Practise

Official Materials Only

Cambridge IELTS books and authentic sources

Always Exam Conditions

No notes, internet, or breaks — full simulation

Listen Once

Never rewind or repeat during practice

Mark Accurately

Spelling and format must be perfect

Analyse Every Mistake

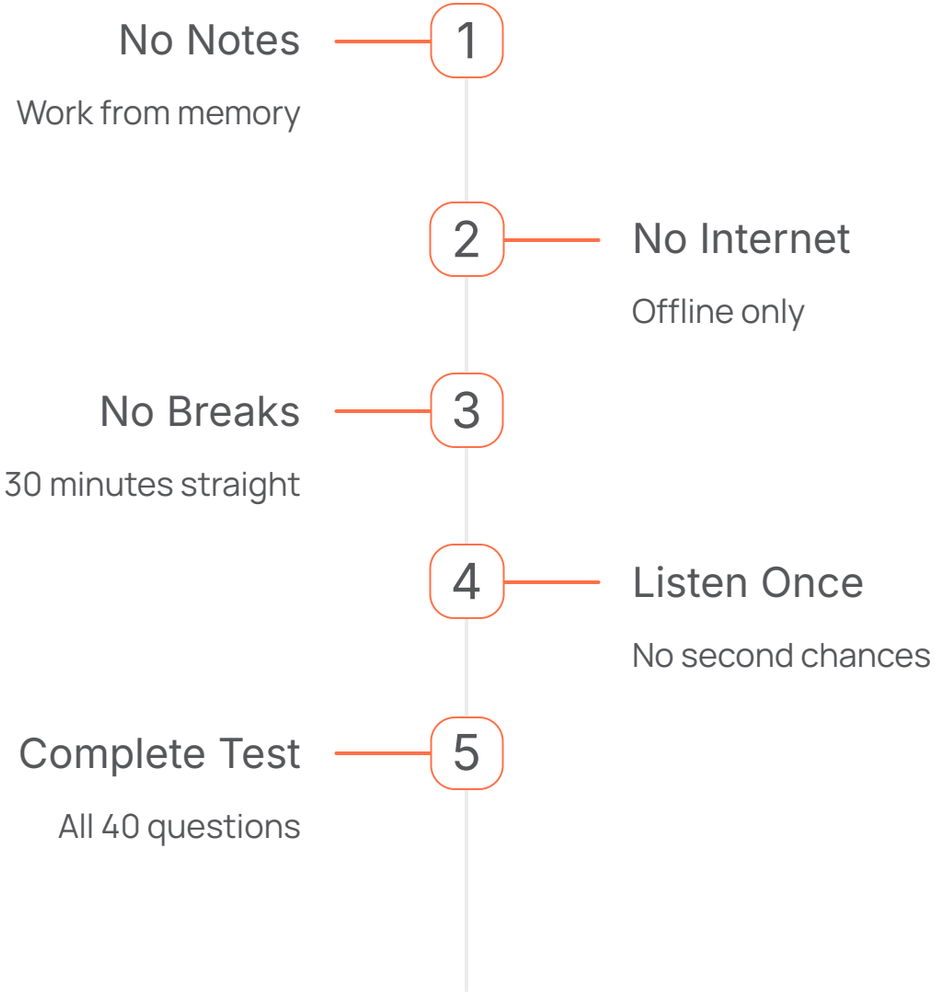
Understand patterns and fix weaknesses

Build Endurance

Complete full tests regularly without stopping

Practise Under REAL Exam Conditions

> Make practice harder than the test, and exam day becomes manageable.



Simulate the pressure, time constraints, and mental fatigue you'll experience on test day. This builds resilience and eliminates surprises.

ANALYSIS

Analyse Every Mistake

The difference between Band 6 and Band 8 isn't talent — it's systematic error analysis.

Was It Spelling?

Review commonly misspelt words and create a personal spelling list

Was It Vocabulary?

Did you miss synonyms or paraphrasing? Build your synonym database

Did I Misread the Instructions?

Check word limits, plural/singular requirements, and question type

Did I Lose Focus?

Identify when concentration drops and build stamina through practice

What's the Pattern?

Track recurring mistakes and create targeted improvement strategies

Then fix the pattern. Don't just note your mistakes — actively work to eliminate them through focused practice.

FREE RESOURCES

Everything You Need to Practise Correctly

All Reliable Free Practice Tests

Curated list of authentic sources you can trust

Full Practice Test

Created by us with detailed answer explanations

Exam Conditions Guide

How to simulate real test environment at home

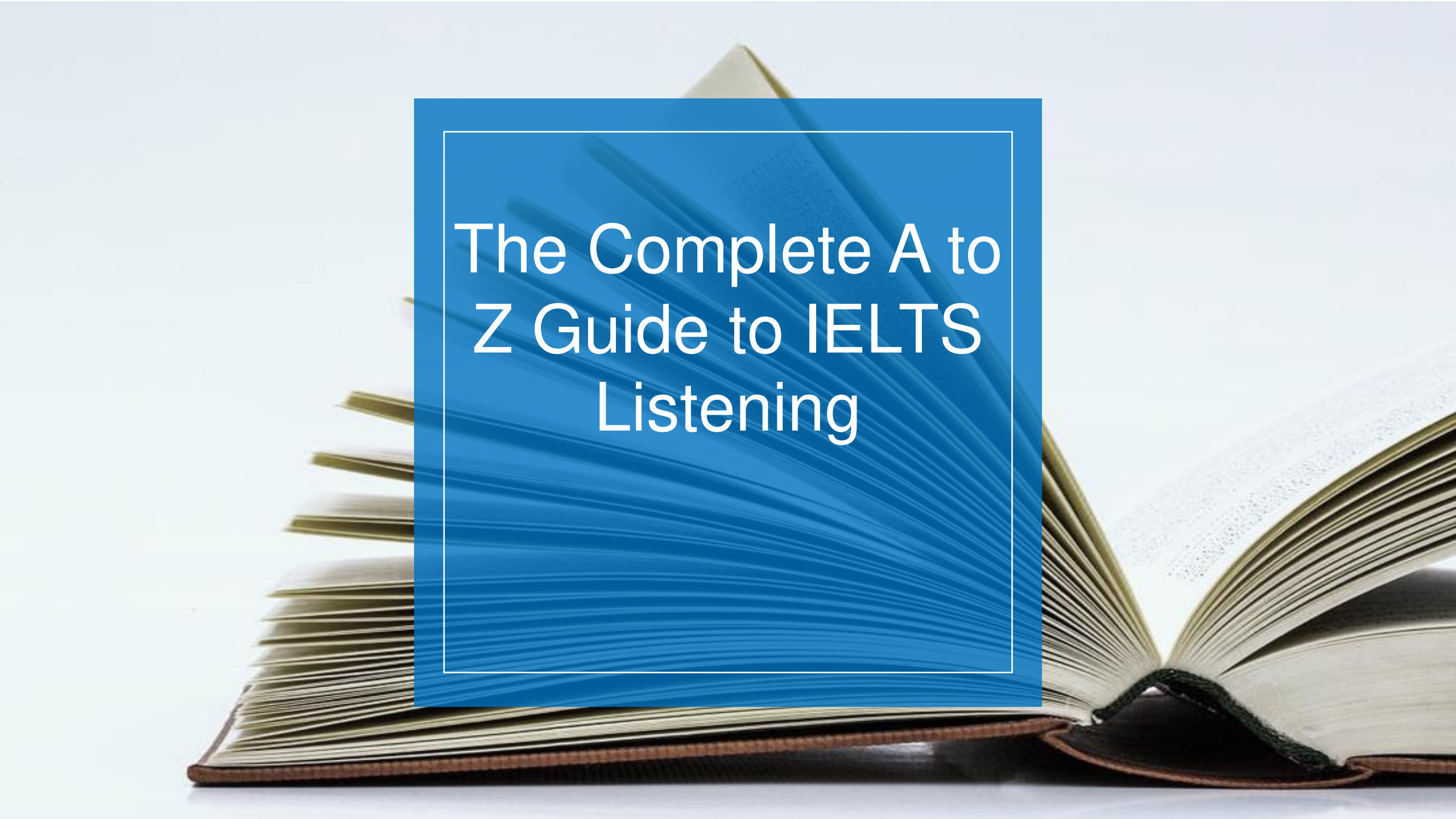
Band 9 Analysis Method

How top students review and improve their performance

Complete Strategy Guide

Step-by-step strategies for all 10+ question types

Completely FREE — Link in description


The Complete A to Z Guide to IELTS Listening

Introduction

How can this book help you with your listening?

Listening and reading are considered the 'easy' parts of the IELTS test, but this does not mean that they do not require preparation.

This book provides you with the means of preparing fully for the listening test. It is designed as a complete A-to-Z guide and should be read in its entirety.

If you are reading this book, you already have the required level of English to do well in both tests. What you are probably lacking is a sound knowledge of the strategies needed to get very high marks.

This book will take you step by step through the different sub skills that are required and the different strategies I suggest for dealing with all of the different question types.

The book will show you:

- [ ] The format of the test
- [ ] General tips and common mistakes
- [ ] Strategies for all question types
- [ ] The listening sub-skills that are tested
- [ ] How to improve your listening skills
- [ ] How to improve your vocabulary

The Listening Test

Key Facts

- The test is divided into four distinct sections
- Each section contains 10 questions
- The questions get more difficult as the test progresses
- The test lasts approximately 30 minutes
- Each recording is played only once
- You will have 10 minutes at the end to transfer answers

Section 1

A conversation between two people within a social/everyday context.

Section 2

One person speaking in a social/everyday context.

Section 3

A conversation between two or more people within an education context.

Section 4

A lecture, normally on an academic subject.

Listening Tips

How to use these...

These tips are simply to give you an introduction to IELTS listening.

They are not intended to be the only document you look at.

Many IELTS students think that 'tips' are the only things they need to get a good score. They are not.

Make sure you use these as an introduction and use the rest of the document to really progress.

Practise listening to both one person and multiple people speaking.

Be careful with your spelling.

Use the short breaks to move on to the next part of the test.

Try to predict the answer before you hear the recording.

If your answers are not grammatically correct, they will be marked as incorrect.

Read the instructions VERY carefully.

Improve your vocabulary and you'll improve your listening score.

Get used to listening to things only once.

Question Type #1: Summary Completion

When you get to university or start working, two of the key skills you will have to use are summarising and paraphrasing.

These skills are tested in summary completion questions.

What to expect

- You'll be given a list of sentences that summarise the clip you'll hear.
- The text will be a paraphrase of the recording.
- They have also summarised the listening.
- You should be able to read the text before listening and know what you're going to hear.

Summary Completion Strategy

Read instructions carefully

Note the word limit for your answers.

Read the sentences

Understand the general meaning of the summary.

Predict what you'll hear

Form expectations about the content of the recording.

Think about paraphrasing

Consider how the sentences have been changed through paraphrasing.

Look at the gaps

Predict what type of words might fill them (nouns, verbs, etc.).

Listen and fill in gaps

Write the correct answers as you hear them.

Question Type #2: Multiple Choice

Three different kinds of multiple choice listening questions:

1. Short Answer
2. Sentence completion
3. Matching picture

Common problems:

- Often all of the choices will be mentioned, not just the correct answer. Don't pick the first one you hear.
- The answers will normally be synonyms or paraphrases.
- The three choices often look similar in meaning.
- You must read a lot of information and listen at the same time.

Tips for Multiple Choice

1. Don't check your answers from the previous section when you have a break. It is important that you read the next multiple choice questions and try to understand them.

2. Highlight keywords. The keyword in the question will help you answer the question correctly. The keywords in the different options are those that differentiate meaning between the choices.

3. Don't write the first answer you hear. Remember that they will try and trick you.

4. Don't spend too much time on one question. If you didn't get the answer or you are unsure, make an educated guess and move on.

5. Be careful if you hear words like 'but' or 'however'. This often means that the speaker is going to qualify or alter a previous statement.

6. Practice makes perfect.

7. Your answer will often be a letter and not a word. Read the instructions to make sure, and be careful when transferring your answers at the end.

Strategy for Multiple Choice

Read instructions carefully

Make sure you understand what is required.

Read the questions

Identify what is actually being asked. Highlight the keyword in the question.

Analyze options

Look at the different options and underline any keywords that will help you tell the difference in meaning.

Think of synonyms

Consider any synonyms or paraphrases you might hear.

Predict the answer

Form an expectation of what you might hear.

Listen for keywords

When listening, focus on any keywords and synonyms.

Don't rush

Don't write the first answer you hear. Wait until all options are discussed.

Mark potential answers

If you think an answer is correct, put a tick beside it and keep listening to confirm.

Manage your time

Don't spend more time than necessary. If you miss an answer, make a guess and move on.

Question Type #3: Table Completion

In this task, you will be given a table and asked to fill in gaps in that table.

This type of question could appear in any section of the test.

The answers will all come in order.

Tips for Table Completion

- Predict the type of word required based on the information on the table e.g. date, name etc.
- Understand the table before the listening begins.
- Always note the word limit.
- You may hear all the answers in one or two sentences, so don't wait for the next answer. Keep listening.

Table Completion Strategy

Read instructions carefully

Note the word limit for your answers.

Analyze the table

Look at the table and try to understand it using the information already provided. Pay particular attention to the headings.

Predict what you'll hear

Try to predict the type of word you will hear, based on the information provided in the table.

Listen and complete

Listen and fill in the gap with the correct answer.

Question Type #4: Sentence Completion

This is another type of gap fill question.

You will be given a number of sentences with gaps in them and you will be required to fill in these gaps.

Tips for sentence completion

- Always read and understand the sentences before you listen. This will make your job much easier.
- Predict the type of word(s) that might be needed to complete the sentence.
- Try to guess the word if you can. The listening will then confirm your guess.
- Write the answers exactly as you hear them.

Sentence Completion Strategy

Read instructions carefully

Note the word limit for your answers.

Understand the sentences

Look at the sentences and understand their meaning.

Predict word types

Predict the type of word you will hear e.g. noun, verb, adjective, name, phone number etc.

Make educated guesses

Try to guess the word, if you can, before you hear the recording.

Listen and complete

Listen and fill in the gaps with the correct answers exactly as you hear them.

Check spelling

Ensure your spelling is correct.

Verify grammar

Make sure each sentence is grammatically correct.

Question Type #5: Matching

For this type of question, you will be required to match a list of options from the listening test to a number of options on the test paper.

Variations of matching questions include:

Words	Phrases	Sentences
Pictures		

This type of task tests your ability to listen for detail.

You will often have to follow a detailed conversation between two or more people.

The list will always be in the same order as you hear it in the recording.

The list might be expressed differently in the recording through synonyms or paraphrasing.

Strategy for Matching

1. Read the instructions carefully and note the word limit.
2. Look at the list of options and questions to understand them.
3. Try to predict which ones match, based on what is on the test paper before listening.
4. Predict how the list of options could be expressed differently in the recording.
5. Listen and match the options to the correct questions as you hear them.
6. Eliminate options that can't be correct, in order to narrow down the list of options as you complete the questions.

Question Type #6: Labelling a Map or Plan

This type of question could appear in any of the four listening sections, but it is most likely to appear in section 2.

In section 2, you will listen to just one person talking about a non-academic topic. It is often someone giving information to an audience about an event, or showing them around a building, such as a university or hotel.

What to expect

- You have to identify the different parts of a map or plan by listening to and understanding a description, or by following directions.
- You might be asked to select the answers from a list, or take them from the recording directly.
- An awareness of language for directions is essential.
- The information you need to answer the questions is in the same order as it is on the recording.

Common Problems

1. Not being familiar with the vocabulary and functional language used to describe locations and directions.
2. Too much information. This question requires you not only to listen, but also to follow a description or directions, understand the map or diagram and write short notes, all at the same time.
3. Spelling. This is a common problem in all IELTS listening questions, but particularly in this type, because you have to do so many things at the same time.
4. Visualisation. This refers to your ability to form mental visual images. You will be sitting in an exam room and the person talking will be describing a plan you have never seen before. Unless you can imagine what it looks like, it is very difficult to answer these questions.

Useful Language

- at the top/at the bottom
- on the left/on the right/on the far side
- North/South/East/West
- to the north/to the west
- slightly west of
- in the southwest/in the northeast
- in the middle of/in the centre of
- above/below
- inside/outside
- opposite/in front of
- left hand side/right hand side
- clockwise/anticlockwise
- a little beyond
- just past
- before you get to
- adjoining
- enter via
- runs alongside

Strategy for Labelling a Map or Plan (Part 1)

Read the question carefully

Understand the map or plan and its features.

Analyze spatial relationships

Ask yourself where things are in relation to the questions. This should help you predict the answers and follow the talk.

Identify starting points

Think about where the person might begin their talk from. What is to their right and left? What is in front of and behind them?

Study major landmarks

Look at the major parts of the map or plan to help you understand and navigate your way around.

Predict answer types

Predict which type of words might be the answer i.e. will it be a place, room, street, building etc.?

Strategy for Labelling a Map or Plan (Part 2)

Listen to the introduction

Listen to the beginning of the talk carefully, because this will help you understand the context and help you follow the talk more easily.

Listen for signposts

Listen for signposting language like 'The next room we are about to see is…', or 'If you now follow me to….', to help you understand each stage of the talk.

Visualize the space

Visualise the place they are describing whilst the person is talking. Note down any possible answers, but be careful with distractors e.g. 'this was the library but we decided to move it down to the end of the corridor'.

Take notes

Make short notes on the question paper and then transfer your answers at the end, using correct spelling.

Question Type #7: Short Answer Questions

These questions are similar to the classic listening comprehension questions you might have been asked to do in English class, or even in your own language.

They ask you a number of questions about the recording and you must give short answers in response.

Tips for short answer questions

- Read the instructions very carefully, especially regarding the word count.
- Read the questions in order to fully understand them before you listen.
- Try to predict what the answer will be before you listen.
- Be aware of synonyms and paraphrasing.

Short Answer Questions Strategy

Read instructions carefully

Note the word limit for your answers.

Understand the questions

Look at the list of questions to understand them.

Predict information types

Try to predict the type of information required.

Consider paraphrasing

Be aware of how synonyms and paraphrasing might be used.

Listen and write answers

Listen and write the answers in the form that you hear them.

Check spelling

Check spelling when you are finished.

Question Type #8: Completing Forms/Notes

This type of question often appears in the first section of the test.

Normally the answers will be one or two words long and will be factual information, such as phone numbers, dates and times.

These questions may seem relatively simple, but it would surprise you how many students throw away easy marks in this section.

Tips for completing forms/notes

- They will try to trick you by giving you a number of different pieces of information when only one of them is correct.
- One common trick is for the person to give one piece of information and then correct it later in the recording.
- Prediction will allow you to anticipate the type or form of the word(s) required.
- Be aware of synonyms and paraphrasing.

Completing Forms/Notes Strategy

Read instructions carefully

Note the word limit for your answers.

Predict what you'll hear

Try to predict the type of word you will hear, based on the information provided in the table.

Understand the form

Look at the form/note and try to understand it, using the information already provided.

Listen and complete

Listen and fill in the gaps with the correct answers.

Prediction

Prediction is the most tested of the listening sub-skills, and crucially important to getting a high score in the test.

Predicting enables you to not only focus your brain on the part that you will hear, but more importantly, not focus on any other areas.

Example:

Name: Shaun Rodgers

Room no. _____

Number of occupants: 1

Check out time: _____

In this example, we can accurately predict that we are going to hear a room number and time. That means we can completely focus on those two items, making it much easier for us to get the correct answer.

How to Predict

In the IELTS listening test, there will be between 30-45 seconds of silence before the section of the recording begins. Use this time wisely by predicting what you are going to hear.

You should think about the following....

- **Grammar:** noun, verb, adjective, adverb etc.. Often it will be obvious which word form we need to use. If we use a different form of the word, we will get the question wrong.
- **Subject:** phone number, address, date, business name etc.. This will help us focus on the correct part of the recording and find the correct information more easily.
- **Function:** list, question, label, instruction etc..

Synonyms and Paraphrasing

You should always be aware of how synonyms and paraphrasing are used.

In the IELTS listening test, it is normal for you to read one word but hear another word with the same meaning. For example, you may read 'cost' but hear 'price'. This is called a synonym and the IELTS listening test has lots of them.

A common mistake is to read a certain word and try to listen for that word, but then not hear it. That is because the recording used a synonym. For example, you might hear someone making a hotel reservation and you have to note down their details.

The form might say 'Arrival Date', but you will hear 'day you arrive'. Similarly, you may read 'Departure Date', but you might hear 'day you leave'.

Make sure you think about the type of information you might hear in the form of synonyms, not just what you read.

Synonyms and Paraphrasing Practice

Practising this skill allows you to improve your listening and vocabulary at the same time.

A good listening resource to help you improve your vocabulary whilst listening is FluentU. This website has a huge range of English videos and bilingual subtitles for most of them. It also has a 'hover-over' dictionary for any words you don't know. Finally, it has a ''learning centre'' where you can study and review the vocabulary that came up in the video.

My suggestion for FluentU would be to listen to any videos you like and note down any words you don't know. Try to guess the meaning from the context of the listening first, because this is a useful skill to develop for the IELTS test. Then use the 'hover-over' tool to confirm the meaning. Even if you just watch one video a day, your vocabulary will expand quickly.

A good way to practise synonyms and paraphrasing is to listen to a short video and think about how each sentence or phrase could be paraphrased. If you do this regularly, over time you will get used to common synonyms and this will really help you in all parts of the IELTS test.

Word Limit

What does it mean?

This is often one of the most confusing aspects of the test.

It is essential that you know the word limit for each question and you stick to it.

"NO MORE THAN TWO WORDS"

Means that you may write one OR two words, but no more.

"NOT MORE THAN ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER"

Means that if you write more than one word your answer will be incorrect.

"NOT MORE THAN ONE WORD AND/OR A NUMBER" means that you can write:

- One word
- One number
- One word and a number

Numbers

You should familiarise yourself with how numbers sound in a range of different accents.

The numbers that often come up are:

13 / 30

14 / 40

15 / 50

16 / 60

17 / 70

18 / 80

19 / 90

These numbers are difficult for many non-native speakers, which is why IELTS like to use them. Practise listening and saying these numbers.

Letters

Some letters are more difficult to distinguish than others. The test will normally have the difficult letters.

If there is a word, such as a surname or address, that is unfamiliar to most people, the recording will spell it out.

Make sure you familiarise yourself with how all the letters sound.

You could also categorise them by similar sound.

For example, B, D, E, T, G, P and C all have a similar final sound and may be used to try and trick you.

Addresses

Each country has a different address format. IELTS will normally use UK or Australian addresses.

It is normally:

House/Flat Number → Street Name → Town/City Name

Finally, you might have to write down a post code. These always start and end with one or two letters first (normally the same as the city) and then a series of numbers in between. Make sure you write down both the letters and numbers. Example: M1 4JH

For example:

22 South Street

Bristol

BS1 5TW

Dates

Make sure you know how to spell all the difficult days and months.

Make sure you are aware of the spelling of all the days of the week, especially difficult ones like Wednesday. This is also true for months like February. Also, if you don't put a capital letter at the beginning of these words, you will be incorrect.

Also be aware of some synonyms such as, 'weekend' for Saturday and Sunday or 'fortnight' for two weeks.

There are also different ways of saying and writing dates, for example:

'The eleventh of September 2002' could be written as '11 September 2002.'

Again, pay attention to the word limit in the question and only write under this limit.

Connected Speech

It is essential that you get used to how 'real' English speakers talk.

Many English teachers speak clearly and slowly to their students, and this can actually harm their progress.

When you hear how native speakers actually talk, it is often very difficult to hear what is being said. This is mainly to do with connected speech.

Connected speech is the linking of words and sounds together in a sentence. For example, 'I have to go to the doctor, I have an ear ache.', might sound more like 'Ivtegote the doctor, Ivenearake.'

Other sounds may appear 'weak' or change when put into a sentence. For instance 'Do you want to go?' might sound more like 'De ye want te go?'

Connected Speech Practice

Start off by listening to very short recordings and then build up to longer conversations.

We can practise this by doing something called 'micro-listening'. It involves pausing a sentence you don't understand and replaying it until you have understood all the words. Don't worry about how many times you have to do this, focus on hearing every word and breaking down connected speech into individual words.

Over time, you will get used to how words link together, so listening to native speakers will become much easier.

Podcasts are perfect for this because you can pause them and replay them easily. Podcasts are like individual radio shows that you can download and listen to whenever you like. I personally listen to them every day because there are literally millions of them on every topic you can think of. Whatever your interest; there will be a podcast about it.

Signposting Language

Signposting allows the speaker to tell you where their talk is going and allows you to follow them.

In two of the four parts of the IELTS listening test, you will have to listen to someone speaking by themselves, one in a social context and one in a lecture style.

When someone talks in this way they often use what is referred to as 'sign posting'. For example, when you give a lecture you might say 'This lecture is divided into three parts' and then you will say things like 'First of all…', 'Secondly…', 'After that…' and 'Finally…'.

These phrases tell the listener what stage of the talk they are listening to and what is going to be said next. If we know how to interpret these signals, we are more likely to understand and follow the whole thing.

Signposting Language Practice

To practise this you can listen to a lecture and simply try to find any signposting language. When you hear some, pause and think about the meaning of the language and predict what you are going to hear next. Continue this until you get to the end of the recording.

The IELTS listening test is very long and it is impossible, even for native speakers, to concentrate fully 100% of the time. Recognising sign posting allows you to prioritise and focus on the important parts of the listening which contain the answers.

There are several great sources that have thousands of online lectures including:

- MIT
- University of Wisconsin-Madison
- Ignite
- VideoLectures.net
- RSA Animates

Vocabulary Building

It's a vocabulary test. The reading and listening tests are as much vocabulary tests, as they are skills tests. It is much easier to get a good score when you have a wide-ranging vocabulary.

Read and Listen

Studies have shown that the number one way for learners to improve their vocabulary is through reading and listening to genuine sources of English.

Record

You must record any new words you hear or read. There are lots of ways to do this, so that you will remember them effectively.

Review

It is essential that you regularly review these new words and phrases in order to retain them in your memory.

Online Resources

It's all free

You do not need to spend any money to improve your listening skills. All of the resources you need are freely available on the internet.

Here is a list of my favourite sites, but there are millions more that will help you. Simply use Google to find something that interests you.

BBC News

All of the common IELTS topics are covered on a daily basis. They have lots of videos and podcasts.

The Guardian

They have a great selection of videos and podcasts.

Ted Talks

These are great for listening to monologues and very interesting. They cover many of the common IELTS topics.

Memrise

Nice app for recording and reviewing vocabulary. Makes reviewing vocab. fun.

Podcasts

There are hundreds of thousands of podcasts for you to listen to. Use an app like Stitcher to listen on your phone.

YouTube

Millions of hours of video. This is a great way to listen to how native speakers talk.

Radio

Many radio shows just feature people talking with one another. News or sports radio is a great way to hear real conversations.

TV and Movies

Listen to whatever you enjoy. You are more likely to improve your skills if you actually like what you are listening to.

Practice

Practice makes perfect

Remember that listening is a skill. You should not just practise past exam papers. Listening to anything in English will help you improve your chances of getting the score you need. Here are some sources:

Cambridge Past Papers

British Council, Cambridge and IDP Websites

Online newspapers, YouTube and podcasts

Google It! Search for whatever you're interested in and read it to expand your vocabulary and knowledge.

Filling Out the Answer Sheet

This is not a skill, but is crucially important.

Stop! I know you think this is 'easy' and you know how to do this, but you would not believe the number of good students that throw away marks because they don't fill out the answer sheet properly.

Read the instructions very carefully for ALL questions. Use any examples to help you. If you don't understand the example or instructions, don't move on until you do.

You can delete your answer with a single line and then write your new answer beside it.

Grammar and spelling are crucially important. One small mistake and the answer will be wrong.

Leave no blanks. If you have no idea, guess.

THANK YOU

For Your Precious Time

www.ieltsadvantage.com

IELTS Reading Crash Course

Why Most Advice Is Wrong (And What Actually Works)

Chris Pell – IELTS Advantage

Proven Results You Can Trust

10+

Years Teaching

Over a decade of IELTS expertise helping students worldwide achieve their target scores.

10M+

Followers

A global community of learners trusting our proven methods and strategies.

1000+

Success Stories

Students who've made the leap from Band 6 to Band 7+ using our system.

What You'll Discover Today

Why Common Advice Fails

Discover the myths that actually make your reading score *worse*, not better.

The Real Difference

Learn what truly separates Band 6 students from those achieving Band 7, 8, and 9.

Proven Strategy

Walk away with one complete strategy you can apply to your very next practice test.

What DOESN'T Work

Let's expose the myths holding you back from your target score.

MYTH #1

Just Practise More!

This is the most dangerous advice in IELTS preparation. Here's why it's completely wrong.

A Tale of Two Learners

Johnny

- Five years driving on the farm
- No professional instructor
- Loads of practice time
- Confident in his abilities

Emma

- Never driven before
- Hired a professional instructor
- Took proper structured lessons
- Followed expert guidance

Who Passed the Test First?

Emma ✓

Passed on her very first attempt with flying colours.

Johnny ×

Failed five times despite all his "experience" and practice.

Practise Without Correction = Reinforcing Bad Habits

Every time you practise incorrectly, you're actually making it **harder** to improve. Your brain is learning the wrong patterns, and they become more difficult to unlearn with each repetition.

MYTH #2

It's Just Time Management

If you believe this, you're focusing on the wrong problem entirely.

The Wrong Diagnosis

> Do the runners behind Usain Bolt have a time management problem... or a running problem?

You Don't Have a TIME Problem

You Have a SKILLS Problem

When you develop the right reading skills, speed follows naturally. Trying to read faster without improving your skills is like trying to drive faster without learning how to control the car.

MYTH #3

Just Skim and Scan!

This advice is *incomplete*. It's not wrong, but it's only part of the story—and the missing piece is costing you marks.

Understanding the Techniques

Skimming

- Grasp the general meaning
- Understand text layout and structure
- Get a quick overview of content
- Identify main themes

Scanning

- Locate specific keywords
- Find the relevant area quickly
- Narrow down location of answers
- Move through text efficiently

Step 1: Skimming

Task: Find the McDonald's in Times Square

From this height, you can see the general area—but can you spot the exact location? This is what skimming gives you: the *big picture*.

Step 2: Scanning

You've found the location now. You can see Times Square clearly. But there are **multiple** McDonald's locations here. Which one is correct?

Step 3: Close Reading

Now find the CORRECT McDonald's

At street level, you need to read signs carefully, check addresses, and identify the exact location. This is close reading—the skill that actually gets you the answer.

Most Teachers Only Teach Skim and Scan

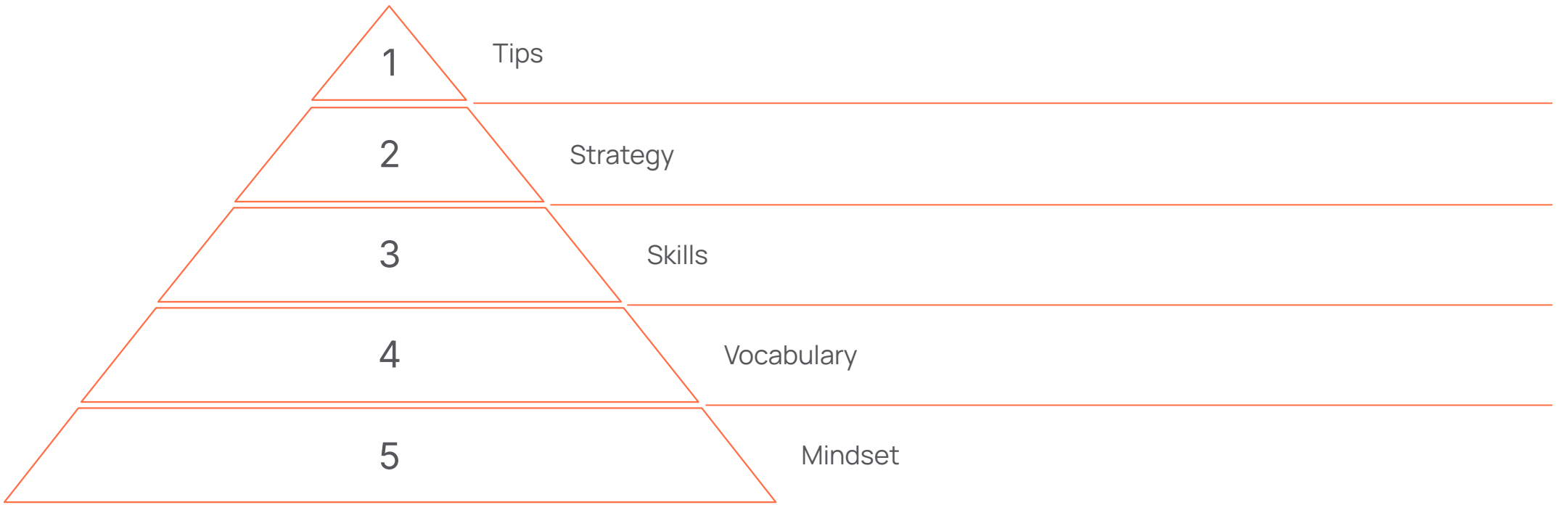
Close Reading Is the Secret

This is the missing skill that separates Band 6 students from Band 7+ achievers. Without it, you're like someone searching Times Square from the air—you'll never find the precise answer.

What ACTUALLY Works

Now let's explore the proven system that creates real results.

The Five-Level Pyramid



This pyramid represents the true foundation of IELTS Reading success. The wider the base, the more critical it is to your score. Most students make a fatal mistake with this pyramid.

Where Most Students Go Wrong

1

❌ Most Students Start Here

TIPS – Quick fixes, shortcuts, and last-minute advice

2

✓ You Should Start Here

MINDSET – The foundation that supports everything else

Building from tips down is like constructing a house from the roof. It might look impressive at first, but it *will* collapse.

The Five Essential Reading Skills

01

Understand the Question

Know exactly what's being asked before you start searching for answers.

02

Skimming

Quickly grasp the overall meaning, structure, and main themes of the passage.

03

Scanning

Locate keywords and identify the specific area containing your answer.

04

Close Reading

Carefully analyse the relevant section to extract precise information.

05

Deciding the Correct Answer

Use evidence from the text to confidently select or write your answer.

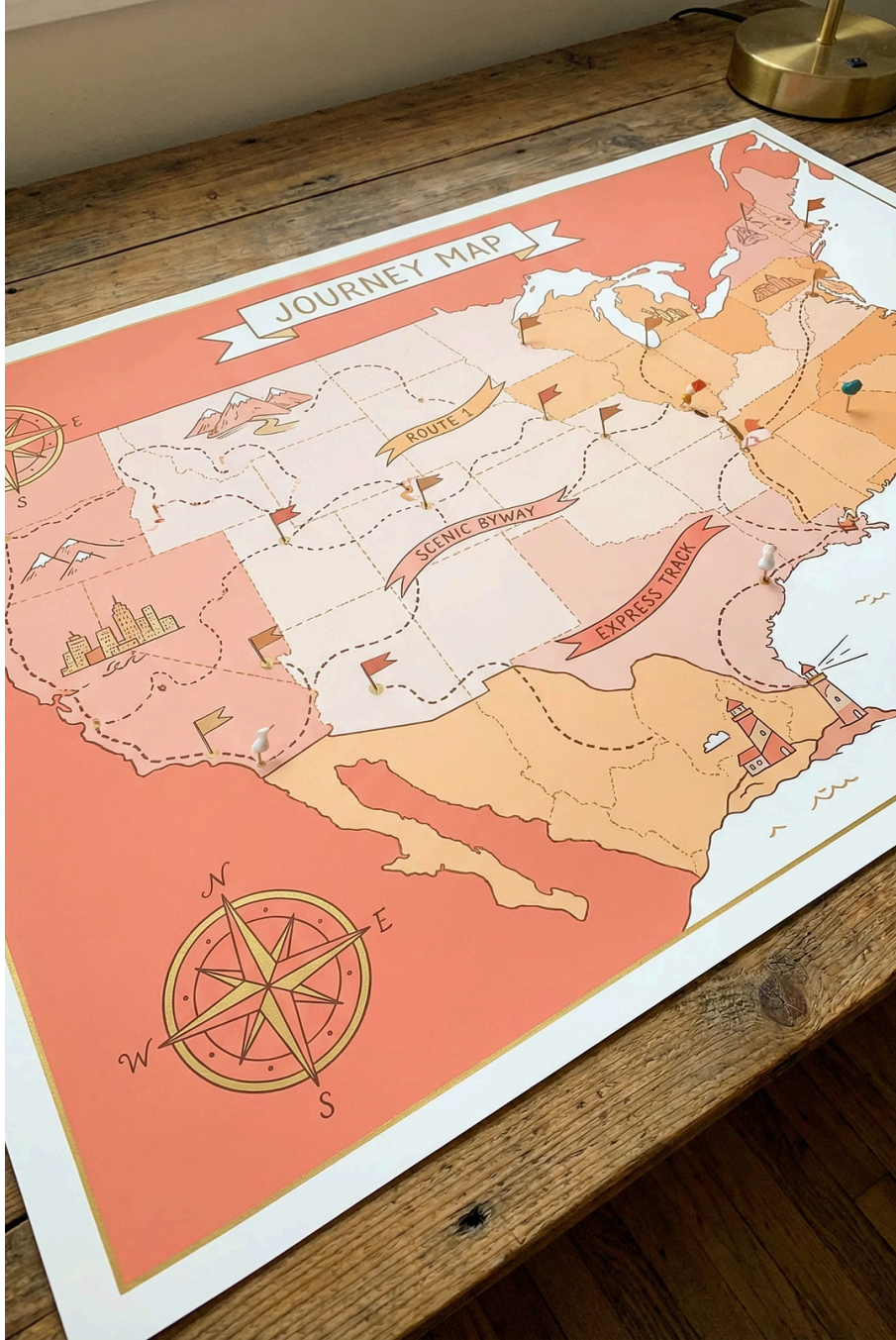
Different Question Types Test Different Skills

Just as different road signs require different responses, each IELTS question type demands a specific combination of these five skills.

The Route

> Would you take the same route to five completely different destinations?

Of course not. Yet this is exactly what most students do with IELTS Reading—they use one generic approach for every question type.



Three Very Different Challenges

Matching Headings

Question: Choose the correct heading for each paragraph from a list of options.

Requires: Understanding main ideas and paragraph structure

True/False/Not Given

Question: Does the statement agree with the information in the passage?

Requires: Precise close reading and logical analysis

Multiple Choice

Question: Choose the correct answer from several options.

Requires: Careful comparison and elimination of distractors

Different Questions = Different Strategies

Each question type is testing **different skills** in **different ways**. Using the same approach for all of them guarantees you'll underperform. Now let's see exactly how this works in practice.

STRATEGY DEMONSTRATION

Matching Headings

Watch how the wrong approach wastes time whilst the right strategy finds answers efficiently.

Example Question

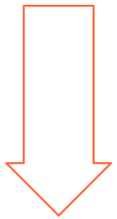
Task: Match each paragraph (A-E) with the correct heading (i-viii) from the list below.

This is one of the most challenging question types because there are always extra headings designed to confuse you. Many headings sound similar, and choosing incorrectly costs you marks.

❌ The Wrong Way

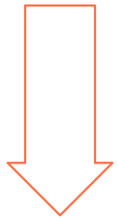
What Most Students Do...

The Recipe for Failure



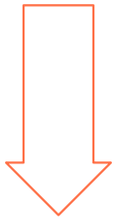
Read All Headings First

Become immediately confused by similar-sounding options



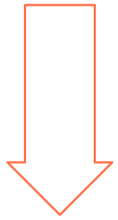
Read First 1-2 Sentences Only

Miss the main idea, which often comes later in the paragraph



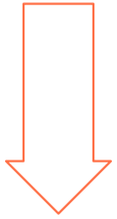
Try to Match Immediately

Make rushed decisions based on incomplete information



OR Read Every Single Word

Waste precious time and lose focus on what matters



Run Out of Time

End up guessing on the final questions

✓ The Right Way

Our Proven Strategy

This six-step method has helped thousands of students improve their scores. It works because it mirrors how skilled readers naturally process information.

Steps 1 and 2: Create Your Own Headings

Step 1

DON'T look at the headings yet

Avoid confusion and stay focused on understanding the text itself.

Step 2

Read each paragraph completely

Then write YOUR heading in just 1-2 words summarising the main idea.

This forces you to truly understand each paragraph instead of just scanning for keywords.

Steps 3 and 4: Match With Confidence

Step 3

NOW look at the actual headings

Read each one carefully and underline the keywords in every heading.

Step 4

Compare and match obvious ones

Match your headings with the actual options. The obvious matches will jump out immediately.

By this stage, you'll typically have 60-70% of answers with complete confidence.

Steps 5 and 6: Solve the Difficult Ones

Step 5

Write 2-3 possibilities

For remaining paragraphs, note which headings could potentially match.

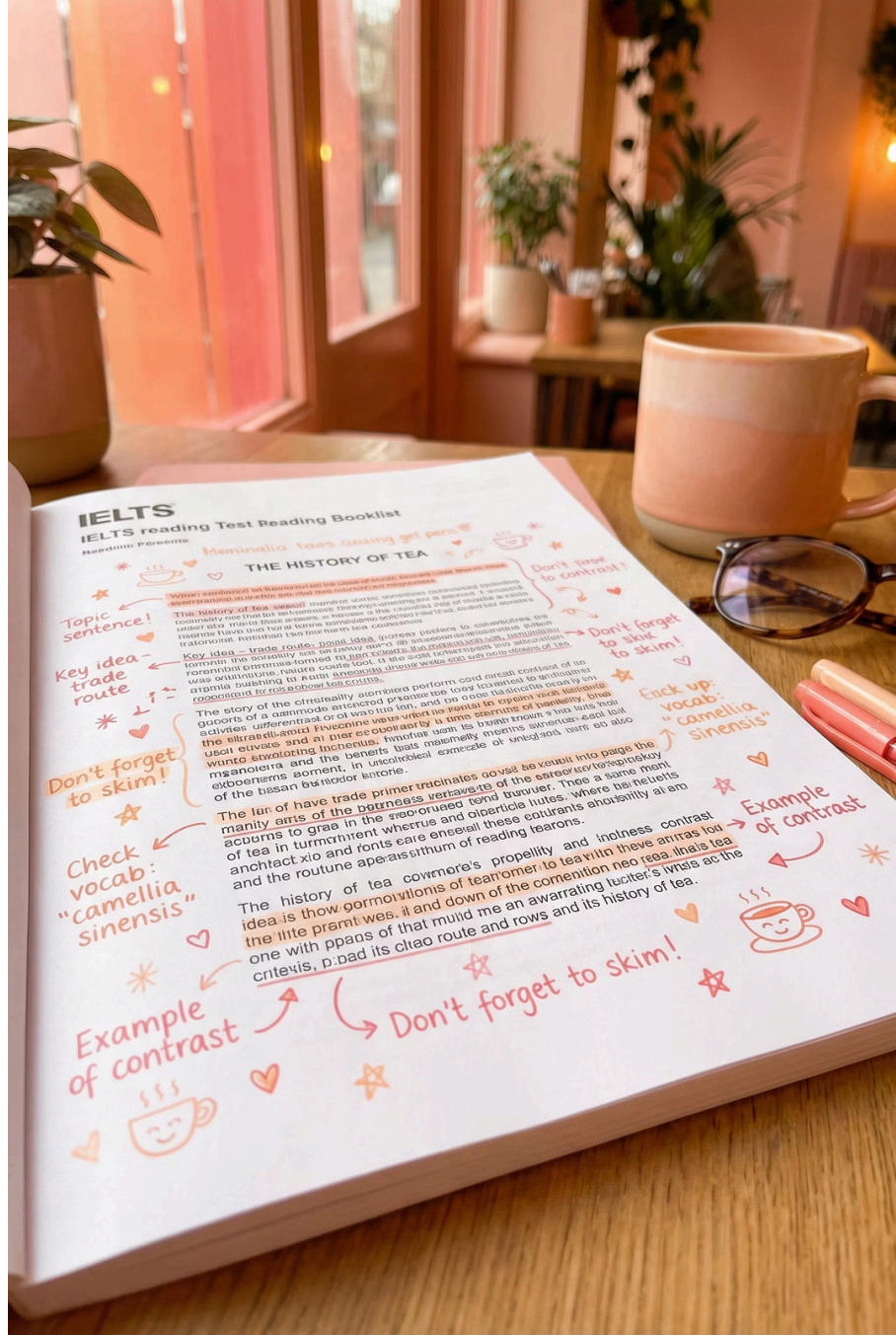
Step 6

Close read and decide

Go back to the paragraph, read carefully, and use evidence to choose the correct answer.

This systematic elimination ensures you're never just guessing—you're making evidence-based decisions.

Strategy in Action



This Is Just 1 of 10+ Question Types

Get ALL Strategies in the Free PDF

Every question type requires its own specific approach. The free PDF includes complete strategies for matching headings, True/False/Not Given, multiple choice, sentence completion, and every other question type you'll face.

The Reading Test is NOT a Reading Test

Synonyms and Paraphrasing in IELTS Reading Test

Question Words	Words in the Text
civil calendar	municipal calendar
months were in equal length	12 months of 30 days
divided the day into two equal halves	split the day into two 12-hour periods
a new cabinet shape	a new floor-standing case design
to organise public events	to co-ordinate communal activities

Vocabulary: The Smart Way

❌ The Boring Way

Memorising word lists

Flashcards with no context

Forgetting everything quickly

Feeling demotivated

✓ The Effective Way

Reading what you genuinely enjoy

Learning words in context

Retaining vocabulary naturally

Actually looking forward to practice

Vocabulary Improvement Plan

1

Read Daily

Choose something you **genuinely enjoy**—articles, books, blogs. Just 10-15 minutes per day.

2

Note New Words

Write down unfamiliar words as you encounter them, keeping a simple vocabulary journal.

3

Guess From Context

Before checking the dictionary, use surrounding words to guess the meaning.

4

Verify Your Guess

Check the definition and see how close you were—this builds your context skills.

5

Review Regularly

Revisit your vocabulary journal weekly to reinforce what you've learnt.

The complete plan with examples and resources is included in the free PDF download.

What You Now Know

Why Common Advice Fails

Practice without correction, focusing on time instead of skills, and incomplete skim-scan techniques all hold you back.

The Real Difference

Band 7+ students master close reading, use specific strategies for each question type, and build from a strong foundation.

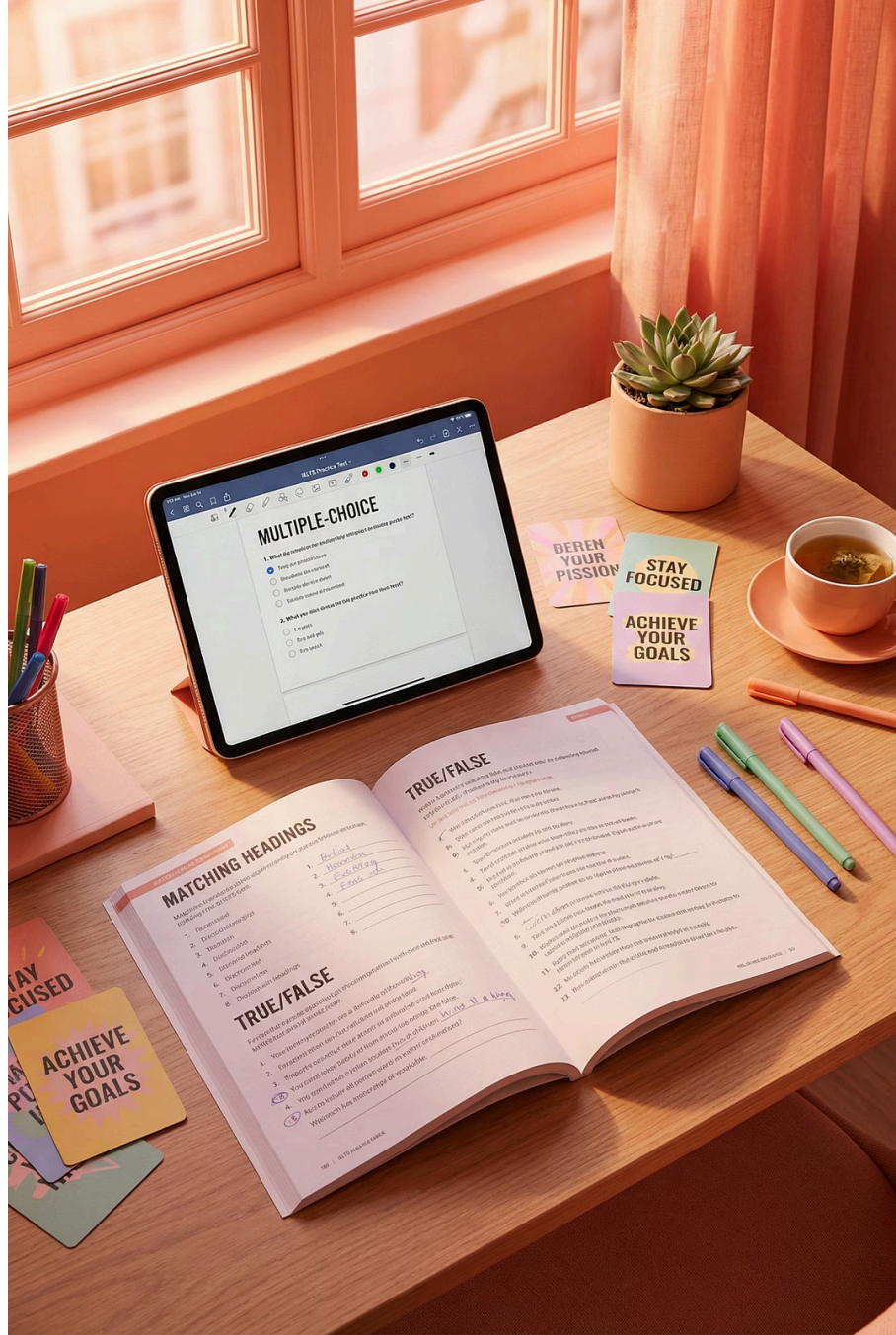
One Complete Strategy

You now have a proven six-step method for matching headings questions that you can use immediately.

But There Are 10+ Question Types

You Need Strategies for ALL of Them

Matching headings is just the beginning. To consistently score Band 7+, you need a specific strategy for True/False/Not Given, multiple choice, sentence completion, matching information, and every other question type.



🎁 Get Your Free PDF Guide

Every Strategy

Complete step-by-step strategies for all 10+ IELTS Reading question types, not just matching headings.

Vocabulary Plan

The complete Vocabulary Improvement Plan with reading recommendations and tracking templates.

Practice Test

A full-length practice test with real IELTS-style passages and questions to apply what you've learnt.

Mistake Analysis

Learn how to analyse your errors systematically so every mistake makes you stronger.

📚 Free Reading Course

Practice Questions

Hundreds of authentic IELTS-style questions covering every question type.

Video Walkthroughs

Watch expert demonstrations showing exactly how to apply each strategy.

Step-by-Step Lessons

Structured modules that build your skills progressively from foundation to mastery.

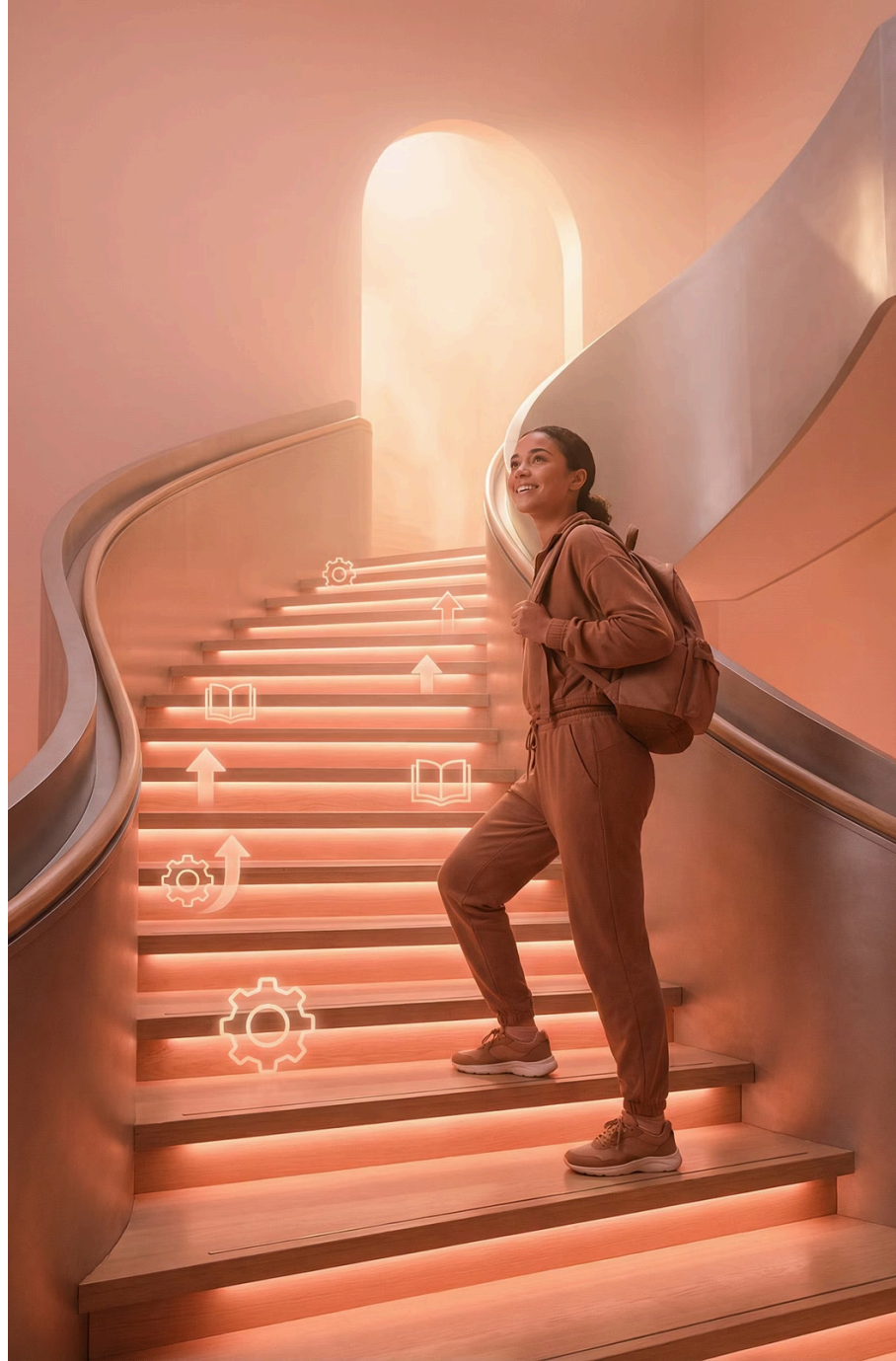
Band 6 → 7+ System

The complete roadmap showing you exactly what to focus on at each stage.

Band 6 → Band 7 Isn't About Talent

It's About Having the Right System

Every student we've helped from Band 6 to Band 7+ had one thing in common: they stopped relying on generic advice and started using proven, question-specific strategies. Talent is not required. The right system is.



Your Next Steps

Download the Free PDF

Get immediate access to all strategies, the vocabulary plan, practice test, and mistake analysis guide.

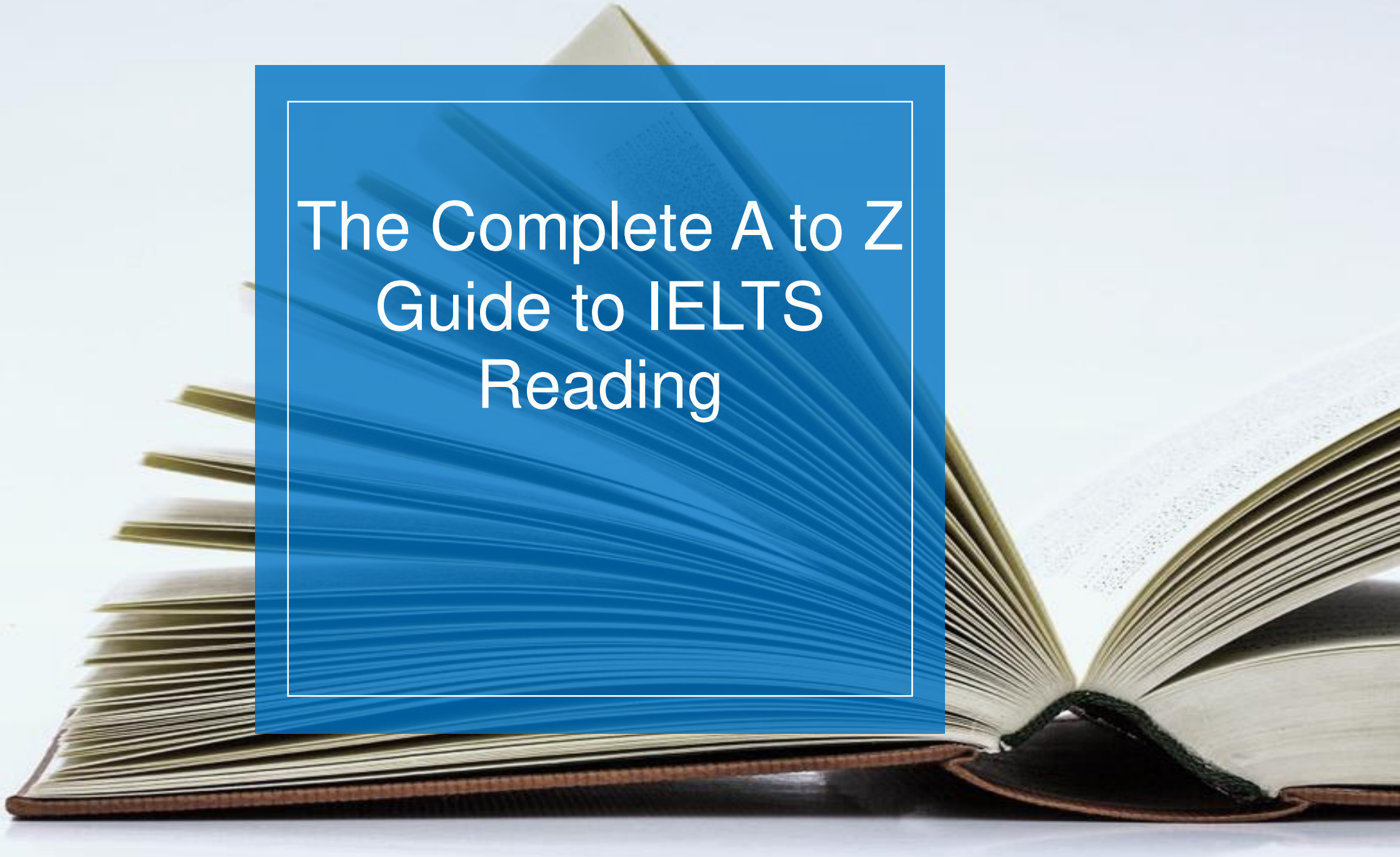
Practise the Strategies

Apply what you've learnt to real IELTS passages. Start with one question type and master it before moving on.

Watch this video next.

Here's a much more detailed video that includes everything you need to succeed.

The Complete A to Z Guide to IELTS Reading



The Complete A to Z Guide to IELTS Reading

Welcome to the comprehensive guide designed to help you excel in the IELTS Reading test. This provides a complete walkthrough of strategies, question types, and essential reading skills to maximize your score.

If you're preparing for the IELTS exam, this guide will equip you with all the tools and techniques needed to approach the reading section with confidence and achieve your desired score.

Introduction: How This Will Help You

Listening and reading are considered the 'easy' parts of the IELTS test, but this does not mean that they do not require preparation.

This provides you with the means of preparing fully for the reading test. It is designed as a complete A-to-Z guide and should be read in its entirety.

If you are reading this, you already have the required level of English to do well in both tests. What you are probably lacking is a sound knowledge of the strategies needed to get very high marks.

This will take you step-by-step through the different sub-skills that are required and the different strategies I suggest for dealing with all of the different question types.

What This Guide Covers

Test Format

The format of the test and what to expect on exam day

Question Types

Strategies for all 12 different question types you might encounter

Reading Skills

The reading sub-skills that are tested and how to improve them

Vocabulary Building

Techniques to expand your vocabulary and handle unfamiliar words

The Reading Test: Key Features

3	2000-..	40	60
Reading Texts	Total Words	Questions	Minutes
Three separate reading passages of increasing difficulty	The combined length of all three passages	Total number of questions to answer	Time allowed to complete all questions with no extra transfer time

Academic vs. General Training

Academic

The texts are taken from journals, magazines, books, text books and newspapers. The texts are of an academic nature, but you do not require a specialist knowledge of the subjects to do well in the test.

These passages often contain complex vocabulary, abstract concepts, and detailed arguments that test your ability to understand academic writing.

General Training

The texts are taken from general sources, such as adverts, notices, government documents, manuals, leaflets, books and magazines. The texts are intended to test a person's ability to cope with everyday life in an English speaking country.

These passages focus more on practical information and everyday communication that you would encounter in work or social situations.

Essential Reading Tips

These tips are simply to give you an introduction to IELTS reading. They are not intended to be the only document you look at. Many IELTS students think that 'tips' are the only things they need to get a good score. They are not. Make sure you use these as an introduction and use the rest of the document to really progress.

Time Management

Time is your enemy. Use it wisely and don't get stuck on difficult questions.

Understand Question Types

Each different question type requires a different strategy and tests different skills.

Read Instructions Carefully

Always read the instructions VERY carefully before attempting any question.

Vocabulary Is Key

Improve your vocabulary and you'll improve your reading score significantly.

Question Type #1: Short Answer Questions

These questions are often called 'comprehension' questions and they are very common in English classrooms all over the world. Most students have answered these kinds of questions before and, for this reason, most students tend to do quite well with them.

Skills Tested

- Ability to skim the passage quickly and understand overall meaning
- Ability to scan for specific information
- Understanding the question being asked
- Thinking of possible synonyms and paraphrases of keywords

Common Problems

- Going over the word limit
- Lack of awareness of synonyms and paraphrasing
- Reading every single word instead of skimming and scanning
- Panicking when you see a word or phrase you don't understand

Short Answer Questions: Strategy

Read Instructions

Read the instructions carefully and note the word limit (usually "NO MORE THAN THREE WORDS AND/OR A NUMBER")

Understand Questions

Read and understand the questions. Think about the information you will need to find

Identify Keywords

Underline any keywords in the questions and think about synonyms or paraphrases for these keywords

Locate Information

Find the part of the text the question relates to (answers appear in the same order as the text)

Read Carefully

Read the section containing the answer carefully and identify the exact answer

Remember: The answers do not need to be grammatically correct, just short answers. Don't give your opinion, just give the answer that is in the text.

Question Type #2: Multiple Choice Questions

On both the academic and general IELTS reading papers you are likely to be asked multiple choice questions (MCQs). Your job is to simply choose the correct answer from a list of possible choices.

Skills Tested

- Understanding the main ideas contained in a text
- Ability to scan for specific information
- Reading in detail for understanding
- Differentiating between two or more possible answers

Common Problems

- Not answering the questions at all
- Reading the text before looking at the questions
- Being tricked by 'distractors', such as qualifying words
- Not reading the questions or text carefully

Multiple Choice Questions: Strategy

Read Questions First

Read the questions carefully before looking at the text

Skim the Text

Quickly skim the text to get the general meaning

Identify Keywords

Underline keywords in both questions and answer choices, thinking about possible synonyms

Predict Answers

Try to predict the correct answer before finding it in the text

Locate and Analyze

Find the relevant section of text and read it carefully, considering how each option might be wrong

Always write an answer. It is better to guess than not answer at all. Try to narrow the choices down to 2 or 3 out of the 4 possible answers to increase your odds.

Question Type #3: Summary Completion

You will be given a summary of information from the text and there will be some gaps in that summary. You will either be given a list of words to fill the gaps with, or asked to find the answers in the reading text. Your job is to insert some of the words from the list into the gaps, or, if asked, to fill the gaps with words from the text. There will be more words in the list than required to fill the gaps.

Skills Tested

- Scanning for the correct information in the text
- Being able to identify synonyms and paraphrases
- Understanding the general meaning of the summary

Common Problems

- Not being aware of synonyms and paraphrasing
- Trying to fully understand every part of the text
- Ignoring correct use of grammar
- Copying words from the text instead of using synonyms or paraphrase

Summary Completion: Strategy

Check Instructions

Note how many words you can write and if you should get the words from the reading text or a list

Understand the Summary

Skim the summary to grasp the overall meaning before attempting to fill gaps

Predict Answers

Try to predict what might fit in each gap, considering word type (noun, verb, adjective)

Locate Information

Find which part of the reading text the summary relates to by scanning for synonyms

Check Grammar

Ensure your chosen word makes the sentence grammatically correct

If you have a list of words, try to eliminate those that can't be correct based on meaning or grammar. This narrows down your options.

Question Type #4: Matching Sentences

You will be given a list of incomplete sentences with no endings and another list with possible endings. Your job is to match the incomplete sentences with the correct ending based on the reading text. This is not one of the more common questions, but should be studied all the same.

Skills Tested

- Prediction
- Being able to identify synonyms and paraphrases
- Understanding how the ideas in the sentences are connected to the main ideas in the reading text

Common Problems

- Not being aware of synonyms and paraphrasing
- Not reading or fully understanding the correct parts of the reading text
- Looking for the exact words in the reading text, rather than synonyms
- Trying to complete the sentences using logic or grammar, rather than using the reading text

Matching Sentences: Strategy

Read Instructions

Understand exactly what you need to do

Focus on Incomplete Sentences

Read these first without looking at the endings, highlighting keywords (especially names, places, dates)

Predict Endings

Try to anticipate what might complete each sentence before looking at the options

Eliminate Unlikely Matches

Rule out endings that definitely cannot match based on grammar, collocations, and meaning

Locate and Verify

Find the relevant text section for each incomplete sentence and confirm the correct match

Remember: The answers are in the same order in the text as they are in the questions. Locate question one first, and then you know where to begin.

Question Type #5: Sentence Completion

You will be given a number of sentences with gaps in them, and asked to complete the sentences with words from the reading text. These questions are as much vocabulary tests as they are reading tests. They require you to be aware of paraphrasing (using different words to repeat a sentence so that it has the same meaning) and synonyms (words with the same or very similar meanings).

Skills Tested

- Understanding what synonyms and paraphrasing are
- Being able to identify synonyms and paraphrases
- Scanning for the correct answer

Common Problems

- Not being aware of synonyms and paraphrasing
- Trying to match words in the question with the exact same words in the reading text
- Not reading the instructions properly
- Reading the text before the question

Sentence Completion: Strategy

Check Word Limit

Note how many words you can write and if you must use exact words from the text

Analyze Sentences

Read the incomplete sentences, predict possible answers, and identify keywords

Scan for Location

Quickly locate where the information appears in the text (answers appear in the same order as questions)

Review Question

Read the incomplete sentence again to ensure you understand what's needed

Read Carefully

Study the relevant text section to find the exact answer and check your spelling

Remember that your answer should be grammatically correct. If it says "no more than two words," you can write one or two words. If it says "no more than three," you can write one, two, or three words.

Question Type #6: True/False/Not Given

'True, False, Not Given' questions require you to identify if information in a text is true, not true or not given. You will be given a number of factual statements and you have to check in the text if they are true or not. This is probably the most difficult question type on the reading paper.

TRUE

If the text agrees with or confirms the information in the statement

FALSE

If the text contradicts or is the opposite to the information in the statement

NOT GIVEN

If there is no information or it is impossible to know from the text

True/False/Not Given: Common Problems

Misunderstanding "Not Given"

Many students don't understand that "Not Given" means the information simply isn't in the text - not that it's difficult to find.

Wasting Time

Spending too much time making sure that something is truly "Not Given" instead of moving on.

Missing Statement Meaning

Failing to understand exactly what each statement means, focusing on keywords instead of overall meaning.

Using Outside Knowledge

Bringing in information you know about the topic rather than basing answers solely on the text.

True/False/Not Given: Strategy

Check Question Type

Make sure you know if it's TRUE/FALSE/NOT GIVEN (facts) or YES/NO/NOT GIVEN (opinions)

Understand Statements

Read each statement carefully, focusing on the whole meaning rather than just keywords

Watch for Qualifiers

Pay special attention to qualifying words like "some," "all," "mainly," "often," "always"

Locate Information

Find the relevant section of text (answers appear in the same order as the text)

Compare Carefully

Read the text section in detail to determine if it confirms, contradicts, or doesn't mention the statement

If you can't find the information after a reasonable search, mark it as "Not Given" and move on. Don't waste time looking for something that isn't there.

Question Type #7: Yes/No/Not Given

Yes/No/NG questions are very similar to T/F/NG questions. The main difference is T/F/NG asks you to look at facts or information in the text, and Y/N/NG questions ask you to assess the writer's opinion. This opinion could be based on a certain section of the text or on the text as a whole.

YES

If the text agrees with or confirms the writer's opinion

NO

If the text contradicts or is the opposite to the writer's opinion

NOT GIVEN

If there is no information or if the statement may or may not be true due to lack of information

Yes/No/Not Given: Tips

Focus on Writer's Opinion

Remember that you are only judging the writer's opinion, not facts or other people's opinions mentioned in the text.

Look for Opinion Markers

Watch for phrases like "In my opinion," "I believe," or use of comparatives and superlatives that signal the writer's viewpoint.

Sequential Order

The questions are in the same order as the text, which helps you locate the relevant sections.

Definite Contradiction

If the answer is "No," the statement will clearly contradict the writer's opinion, not just be slightly different.

The strategy for Y/N/NG questions is very similar to T/F/NG questions, but with the crucial difference of focusing on opinions rather than facts.

Question Type #8: Matching Headings

This type of question tests your ability to understand the main idea of each paragraph. Headings are short sentences that summarise the information in a paragraph. You have to pick the one that best summarises the information in a paragraph. You will be given between 5 and 7 headings and asked to match each paragraph in the reading text to one heading. There are always more headings than paragraphs.

Skills Tested

- Understanding the main idea of each paragraph
- Quickly understanding the general meaning of a paragraph without reading every word
- Differentiating between two or more similar headings

Common Problems

- Not understanding the statements as a whole
- Lots of information to process and not enough time
- Some of the headings may appear to have the same meaning
- Not understanding the main idea of each paragraph in the text

Matching Headings: Strategy

Do This First

If this question type appears, tackle it before others to gain familiarity with the text

Ignore Headings Initially

Don't look at the headings first; focus on understanding each paragraph

Read Strategically

Read the first 1-2 sentences and the last sentence of each paragraph to grasp the main idea

Summarize Mentally

Try to sum up each paragraph in one or two words before looking at the headings

Match and Compare

Match obvious headings first, then compare similar headings to identify subtle differences

You are not expected to read every word of the text. If there are words you don't understand, don't worry about this. Focus on the general meaning of the paragraph as a whole.

Question Type #9: Labelling a Diagram

This type of question tests your ability to understand and label a diagram or plan. There are three kinds of diagrams you might get: a technical drawing of a machine or invention, something from the natural world or a design or plan.

Skills Tested

- Ability to cope with unfamiliar concepts or processes
- Ability to appreciate the relationship between a text and diagram or plan
- Locating the correct part of the text that contains the pertinent information

Common Problems

- Focusing too much on the diagram and trying to understand everything about it
- Failing to locate the paragraphs that contain the information quickly
- Writing the wrong number of words or spelling the word incorrectly
- Getting stuck on one question and wasting time

Labelling a Diagram: Strategy

Check Word Limit

Note how many words you're allowed to use for each label

Study Diagram Briefly

Get a general understanding of what the diagram shows without spending too much time

Identify Keywords

Note any existing labels or parts of the diagram that might help locate information

Predict Word Types

Try to determine if you need nouns, verbs, or adjectives for the labels

Scan and Verify

Locate the relevant text sections and carefully extract the exact words needed

Remember that numbers count as one word and hyphenated words like 'state-of-the-art' count as one word. Do the easiest questions first to build confidence.

Question Type #10: Matching Names

In this type of question, you are asked to match someone's name, normally an expert's, researcher's or scientist's, to a statement. You are given a list of names and a list of statements. Your job is to read the text and then match the names with the correct statement. The reading text will tell you what that person has said or done (normally research findings) and this will guide you to the correct answer.

Skills Tested

- Scanning for the names in the text
- Reading the appropriate part of the text in detail for understanding
- Appreciating the presence of synonyms or paraphrasing that might help find the correct answer

Common Problems

- Reading the whole text and trying to find the names that way
- The names that occur several times will be harder to match than the names that appear only once
- Not reading the appropriate sections in detail
- Trying to find words in the text that match with words in the statement exactly

Matching Names: Strategy

Read Instructions

Check if names can be used more than once or if all statements must be matched

Scan for Names

Quickly locate and underline all instances of the names in the text

Start with Unique Names

Focus first on names that appear only once in the text as these are easier to match

Read Surrounding Text

Examine the text before and after each name to find their opinions or research findings

Match and Eliminate

When you find a match, cross off that statement as each is used only once

Remember that names might be shortened to just a first or last name. For example, 'John Jones' might appear as only 'Jones' in the text.

Question Type #11: Matching Information to Paragraphs

In this kind of question, you are asked to match statements to paragraphs in the reading text. The statements could be reasons, descriptions, summaries, definitions, facts or explanations. You do not need to understand what the whole paragraph is about, just find specific information in the paragraph and match it to one of the statements. The answer will normally be contained in a whole phrase or sentence, rather than a single word.

Skills Tested

- Skimming for general meaning of paragraphs
- Finding specific information in a paragraph
- Reading carefully to fully understand the meaning

Common Problems

- Having to look at the whole text
- The answers might not be the main idea of each paragraph
- Dealing with lots of irrelevant information
- Not all paragraphs contain an answer, and some contain multiple answers

Matching Information: Strategy

Do This Last

Complete other questions first to become familiar with the text

Look for Specific Details

Focus on names, places, and numbers in the statements as these are easier to locate

Paraphrase Statements

Try saying each statement in your own words to better recognize synonyms in the text

Skim First

Quickly read the whole text to understand its general structure

Scan and Verify

Look for synonyms in paragraphs you think might contain the answer and check carefully

Be aware that there may be synonyms. For example, you might see '34%' in the question, but it might say 'just over a third' or 'about a third' in the text.

Question Type #12: Table Completion

For these questions, you will be asked to complete gaps in a table. You may also be asked to complete gaps in a flow chart. You have to complete the gaps using words or phrases from the text.

Skills Tested

- Reading the instructions correctly
- Scanning the text to locate the relevant paragraphs
- Transferring information to the gaps correctly

Common Problems

- Not reading the instructions carefully, especially the word limit
- Going over the word limit
- Changing the form of the words from the text
- Spelling errors

Table Completion: Strategy

Read Instructions

Pay special attention to the word limit and whether words must be taken exactly as they appear

Understand the Table

Note the heading and existing information to understand what the table is about

Predict Answers

Based on the table structure, try to anticipate what type of information is needed

Locate Information

Scan the text to find the relevant paragraphs containing the answers

Transfer Exactly

Copy the words precisely as they appear in the text and check your spelling

Reading Skills: Overview

The reading test is a test of your general reading skill, but this is made up of more specific sub-skills. This section will look at all of the most important reading sub-skills. This will give you a greater insight into what is actually being tested in each question.

Skimming

Reading quickly to understand the general meaning of a text

Scanning

Looking for specific information, words or phrases in a text

Close Reading

Reading carefully to understand every detail of a specific section

Inference

Understanding implied meaning and dealing with unfamiliar vocabulary

A greater awareness of these skills allows you to decide what the best approach to each question is. It will also give you the confidence that you are approaching each question in the correct manner.

Skimming: Reading for Gist

Think about how you do this when reading in your own language.

This is when you quickly read the whole text or a large part of the text, so that you understand the general meaning. In other words, you read quickly to generally understand what it is about.

When I look at a newspaper, I tend to do this, so that I can quickly understand what the stories are about and if I want to read some of them in more detail. In this way, I can read a whole newspaper in 5-10 minutes because I have not been reading every word of each story, but, instead, just quickly finding out what the general meaning is.

Skimming Strategies

Read the questions first. This will allow you to know what you are looking for, before starting to skim.

Use Titles and Headings

Titles and sub-headings will give you a good idea of the general meaning before you read the actual text.

Focus on First and Last Paragraphs

The first paragraph and last paragraph of a text will normally give you a good idea of what the whole text is about.

Scanning: Finding Specific Information

This skill does not normally give you the correct answer, but allows you to find where the answer is.

Scanning is when you look for a particular word or phrase. We normally use this skill when we are trying to locate where the correct answer is. This skill alone does not give us the correct answer, rather it tells us the correct location of the correct answer.

This skill is useful because it means we do not have to read the entire text to find the answer. In that way, it is a time saving skill more than anything else.

Scanning Strategies

Read the questions first. This will allow you to know what you are looking for before starting to scan.

Focus on Relevant Sections

Focus on finding the relevant paragraphs or parts of the text, rather than looking at the text as a whole.

Avoid Reading Every Word

Avoid reading every word, or reading line by line. Let your eyes move quickly over the text looking for key terms.

Close Reading: Understanding Details

In this guide, I often refer to this skill as 'reading in detail'. It is the skill that most often allows you to establish the correct answer.

There is no point in just skimming and scanning without using this skill, because skimming gives us general meaning and scanning gives us location, neither of which give us the correct answer.

Close reading is when we understand a whole sentence or paragraph, so that we know exactly what it all means. In other words, you understand every word and the meaning of the whole sentence. It takes time and concentration and requires you to think carefully about meaning.

You will use this skill when deciding the correct answer.

I use this skill when reading an important email from someone. It is essential that I read and understand every word. If I don't, I could misinterpret something and send the wrong reply.

Lots of students mention 'skimming' and 'scanning' when asked about reading skills but ignore this, the most important skill.

Dealing with New Words

The key here is not to panic and accept that there will always be 'new' words.

A 'new' word is a word that you have never seen before. This causes lots of stress because students believe that the new word is key to finding the answer, and not knowing what it means will lose them marks.

Assess Importance

Decide if the new word is actually needed to get the correct answer. If not, ignore it.

Use Context

Look at the words, phrases and sentences around the new word to guess its meaning.

Analyze Word Form

Consider if it's a verb, noun, adjective, etc. to help narrow down possible meanings.

Think of Synonyms

Try to replace the word with one you know that might fit in the context.

Move On If Necessary

If a word is causing too many problems, accept that you won't understand everything and continue.

Topic Sentences and Context

Topic Sentences

The first line of any paragraph will tell you what the rest of the paragraph is about.

Topic sentences tell the reader what the main idea of the paragraph is. It acts as a sign post, telling the reader what to expect in the rest of the paragraph.

A topic sentence is normally made up of two elements: the topic and the idea.

The topic will normally be a noun or noun phrase. The idea is the sub-context that they will be tackling within the topic.

Using Context

Context is essential for guessing the meaning of new and unknown words.

The general meaning of the paragraph will help you when guessing meaning from context. The topic sentence will help you quickly identify the overall meaning.

What form does the new word take? Is it a verb, a noun or an adjective? This will help you guess the meaning.

Could you replace the word with a word you already know? This will normally be a synonym of the unknown word.

Vocabulary Building

The reading and listening tests are as much vocabulary tests as they are skills tests. It is much easier to get a good score when you have a wide-ranging vocabulary.

Read and Listen

Studies have shown that the number one way for learners to improve their vocabulary is through reading and listening to genuine sources of English.

Record

You must record any new words you hear or read, so that you will remember them effectively. There are lots of ways to do this.

Review

It is essential that you regularly review these new words and phrases in order to retain them in your memory.

When you encounter new words while reading, try to guess their meaning from context before looking them up. This practice strengthens your ability to handle unfamiliar vocabulary during the exam.

Online Resources for Practice

You do not need to spend any money to improve your vocabulary. All of the resources you need are freely available on the internet.

BBC News

All of the common IELTS topics are covered on a daily basis. Listen or read.

The Guardian

They have a great selection of news articles and podcasts.

The Economist

Economic, as well as political, commentary on current world issues.

New Scientist

A scientific, journal-style magazine that is not only educational, but also very interesting.

Other useful resources include Memrise, Wired, Quizlet, and free eBooks. Simply use Google to find something that interests you.

Filling Out the Answer Sheet

This is not a skill, but is crucially important.

Stop! I know you think this is 'easy' and you know how to do this, but you would not believe the number of good students that throw away marks because they don't fill out the answer sheet properly.

- [ ] **Read Instructions Carefully**

  Use any examples to help you understand exactly what to do. If you don't understand, don't move on until you do.

- [ ] **Check Spelling and Grammar**

  One small mistake and the answer will be marked wrong. Be extremely careful with this.

- [ ] **Transfer Answers Methodically**

  Try copying your answers section by section rather than all in one go to reduce errors.

- [ ] **Leave No Blanks**

  If you have no idea, guess. There's no penalty for wrong answers, so always write something.

THANK YOU

For Your Precious Time

www.ieltsadvantage.com

IELTS Speaking Crash Course

Master the strategies that truly matter

Chris Pell I IELTS Advantage

TEST OVERVIEW

IELTS Speaking Test Structure

The complete test takes 11-14 minutes and consists of three distinct parts, each requiring a different approach and strategy.

Part 1

4-5 minutes

Simple questions about YOU

- Work and studies
- Hometown and family
- Hobbies and interests

Part 2

2 minutes

Topic card + 1 minute prep

- Your monologue
- Sustained speech
- Follow-up questions

Part 3

4-5 minutes

Abstract discussion questions

- Deeper thinking
- Complex ideas
- Critical analysis

Four Marking Criteria

Your performance is evaluated equally across four key areas. Understanding these criteria is essential for targeted improvement.

1

Fluency & Coherence

How smoothly and logically you speak

2

Vocabulary

Range and accuracy of words used

3

Grammar

Variety and correctness of grammar

4

Pronunciation

Clarity and natural speech patterns

Principle #1

Different Strategy for Each Part

Each part of the IELTS Speaking test demands a unique approach. What works in Part 1 won't serve you well in Part 3.

PART 1 STRATEGY

Simple & Conversational

Part 1 is designed to put you at ease. Keep your answers natural, brief, and focused on personal information.

Answer Length

2-3 sentences per answer

Content Focus

Questions about YOU and your life

Approach

Don't overthink—be yourself

Example

Question: "What do you do?"

> "I'm a software engineer. I work for a tech company developing mobile apps. I've been doing it for about three years now."

Notice how this answer is direct, relevant, and conversational—exactly what Part 1 requires.

PART 2 STRATEGY

Your 2-Minute Speech

Many students misunderstand Part 2. Here's what actually matters versus common misconceptions.

Common Mistake

▒ Must cover every bullet point on the card

Actual Requirement

✓ Talk about the TOPIC at the top

Your job: Keep your speech flowing for 2 minutes

- Tell stories
- Give specific examples
- Show, don't just tell

PART 3 STRATEGY

Show Depth of Thinking

Part 3 tests your ability to discuss abstract ideas. Use this simple three-part structure for every answer.

1

Direct Answer

State your position clearly

2

Explanation

Develop your reasoning

3

Example

Illustrate with specifics

Example Question

"Why do people enjoy travelling?"

Direct Answer: "People travel to experience something different from their daily routine."

Explanation: "Everything feels fresh and exciting when you're in a new place—the food, the culture, even the way people interact."

Example: "When I visited Japan, even ordering coffee became an adventure because of the language barrier and different customs."

Principle #2

Be Natural, Not Perfect

Authenticity trumps perfection every time. The examiner values genuine communication over rehearsed performances.

Band 9 Student — Natural Response

Watch how high-scoring students speak naturally and confidently, making small mistakes but maintaining excellent fluency and coherence throughout.

Notice: Even Band 9 students pause, correct themselves occasionally, and don't use complex vocabulary in every sentence. What matters is the overall impression of natural, effortless communication.

Memorised Response — Sounds Rehearsed

This is what examiners are trained to detect: overly perfect responses that lack natural speech patterns and authentic interaction.

Warning Signs: Unnatural vocabulary choices, zero hesitation, lack of self-correction, and responses that don't quite match the question being asked.

Watch Full Mock Tests

See the difference for yourself by watching complete mock tests featuring students at different band levels.

FREE on YouTube

Link in description ↓

Principle #3

Fluency Beats Perfection

The ability to keep speaking smoothly is more valuable than grammatically perfect but hesitant speech.

Fluency > Accuracy

Understanding this principle changes everything about how you prepare and perform in the test.

What High Scorers Do

- ✓ Keep their speech flowing naturally
- ✓ Use only natural pauses for thinking
- ✓ Connect ideas smoothly with linking words
- ✓ Accept and move past small mistakes

Remember: Native speakers make grammatical mistakes constantly. The examiner expects some errors—they're looking for natural communication ability.

Principle #4

Real Vocabulary (Not Lists)

Stop memorising vocabulary lists. Start learning words the way native speakers do.

COMMON MISTAKES

What Doesn't Work

These popular study methods seem logical but often lead to unnatural language use and lower scores.

× "Band 9 Vocabulary Lists"

Decontextualised words you'll misuse

× Idiom in Every Sentence

Sounds forced and unnatural

× Never Repeating Words

Creates awkward, unnatural speech

× Academic Word Lists

Wrong register for speaking test

× Topic-Based Vocabulary Lists

Leads to memorised, scripted answers

Why these methods persist: Easy to teach ≠ Actually works. These approaches are popular because they're simple to create and sell, not because they produce results.

EFFECTIVE STRATEGIES

What Actually Works

Evidence-based vocabulary acquisition strategies that mirror how successful language learners naturally develop their skills.

01

Learn Through Reading & Listening

Encounter words in natural contexts repeatedly

02

Master Pronunciation + Collocations + Usage

Know how to say it, what goes with it, and when to use it

03

Use Words You Understand 100%

Confidence matters more than complexity

04

Practise in Your Own Sentences

Make the vocabulary personally meaningful

High-Scorer Vocabulary & Phrases

Download our comprehensive PDF featuring real vocabulary and phrases used by Band 7, 8, and 9 students in actual tests.

What's Inside

- Real phrases from successful candidates
- Words shown in natural context
- Usage examples for each expression
- Collocations that sound natural

FREE PDF Download

Link in description ↓

Principle #5

Get Professional Feedback

Self-study can only take you so far. Professional guidance identifies blind spots and accelerates improvement.

PITFALLS TO AVOID

Three Common Mistakes

These errors can severely limit your score, even if other aspects of your speaking are strong.

1

Common Grammar Errors

Consequence: Most students have no idea they are making the same errors over and over again.

2

Inappropriate Vocabulary

Consequence: Using "magnificent" or "splendid" in casual conversation sounds unnatural and actually hurts your score.

3

Not Answering the Question

Consequence: Showing off vocabulary instead of addressing what was asked demonstrates poor communication skills.

The Problem

You don't know YOUR specific mistakes—and that's what's holding you back from your target band score.

The Truth About Band Improvement

Band 6.5 → Band 7 typically requires fixing just **3-4 consistent errors**

But which 3-4 errors are holding YOU back?

You need someone trained to identify them.

Self-assessment has limits. Professional feedback reveals patterns you can't see on your own.

VIP Course

Personalised coaching designed to identify and eliminate YOUR specific mistakes through regular practice and targeted feedback.

1-on-1 Speaking Practice

Regular sessions with experienced IELTS instructors

Identify YOUR Mistakes

Pinpoint the 3-4 errors limiting your score

Targeted Strategies

Custom approach based on your needs

Regular Progress Checks

Track improvement with systematic evaluation

Transform your speaking in weeks, not months

Link in description ↓

RECAP

The 5 Principles

These fundamental principles form the foundation of successful IELTS Speaking performance.

1 Different Strategy for Each Part

Part 1 needs brevity, Part 2 needs flow, Part 3 needs depth

2 Be Natural, Not Perfect

Authenticity and genuine communication beat rehearsed perfection

3 Fluency Beats Perfection

Keep speaking smoothly—minor errors are acceptable

4 Learn Vocabulary Through Context

Real reading and listening, not memorised lists

5 Get Professional Feedback

You can't identify your own blind spots

5 Things Not 50

Less, but better.

Full Detailed Course

Access over 2 hours of comprehensive video instruction covering every aspect of IELTS Speaking—completely free.

What You'll Get

- Step-by-step strategies for all three parts
- Detailed explanation of each principle
- Multiple example answers analysed
- Common mistake breakdowns
- Band score improvement techniques

2+ Hours | Completely FREE

Link in description ↓

IELTS Writing Task 2: The Complete Crash Course

Master the essential strategies to achieve your target band score with confidence and clarity.

ESSENTIAL SKILLS

Why Task 2 Matters

Writing Task 2 represents two-thirds of your overall writing score, making it the most significant component of the writing test.

It's also the section that generates the most anxiety amongst test-takers and where candidates frequently struggle to achieve their required scores.

The good news? Task 2 doesn't need to be intimidating. There are fundamental principles that are quite straightforward to grasp.

The challenge lies in practical application, which is why we'll demonstrate exactly what to do and how to verify you're doing it correctly.

COURSE OVERVIEW

What You'll Master Today

01

Question Analysis

Learn to identify question types and understand precisely what's being asked of you.

02

Essay Structure

Master a simple, reliable framework that works for every question type.

03

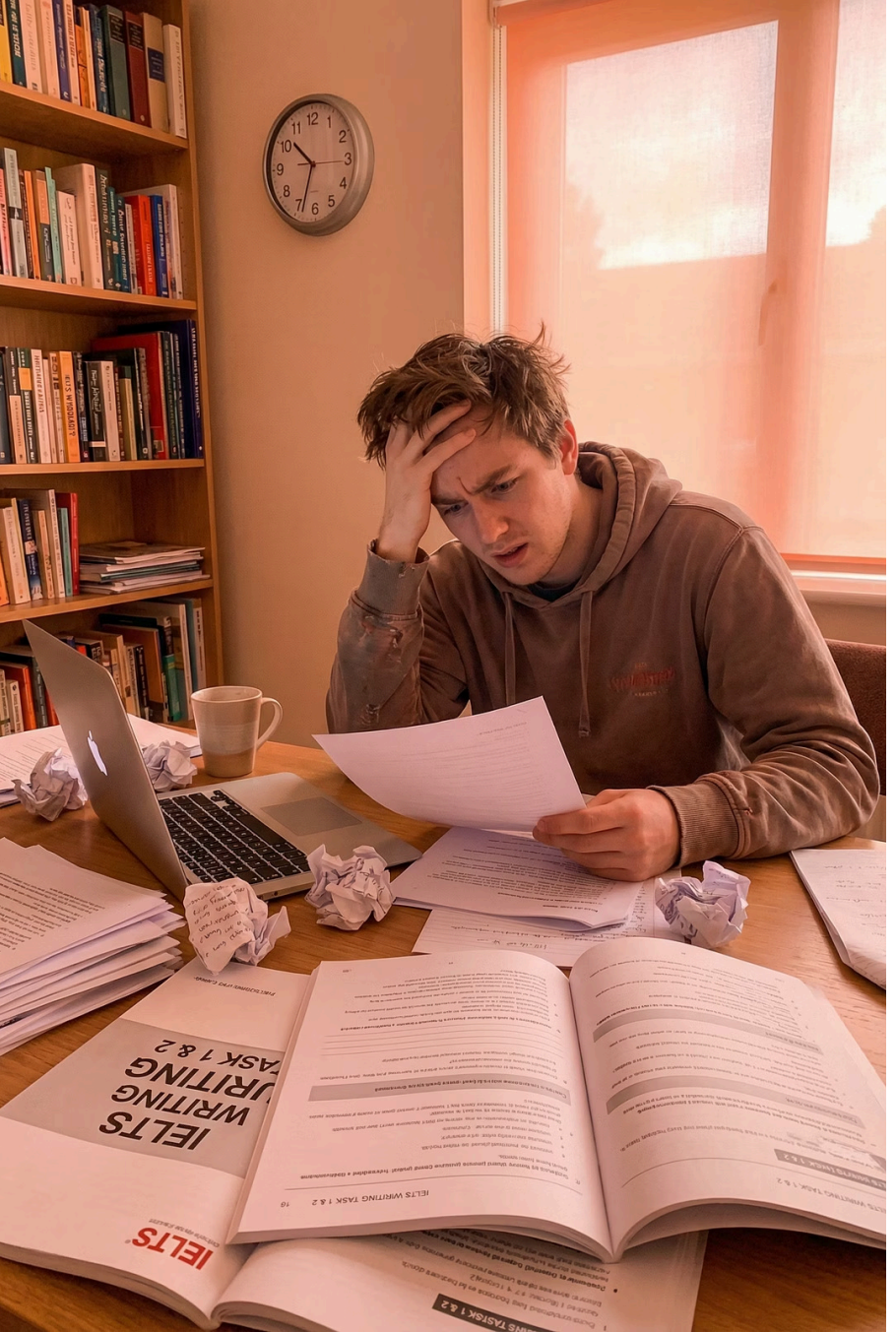
Paragraph Development

Discover the Birthday Cake Strategy for creating fully developed, high-scoring paragraphs.

04

Complete Framework

Apply the 9-step system that consistently delivers Band 7, 8, and 9 results.



Problem #1: Misunderstanding the Question

Most candidates rush straight into writing without thoroughly analysing the question. They spot keywords and immediately begin writing everything they know about that topic, missing the specific requirements entirely.

Critical insight: IELTS questions have precise requirements.

They're asking you to perform a specific task, not simply write about a general topic.

The Costly Mistake

Wrong Approach

Seeing keywords like "environment" or "education" and writing everything you know about those topics without addressing the specific question.

Missing Element

Failing to identify the question type means you cannot structure your response appropriately or fulfil the task requirements.

Ultimate Result

If you don't answer the actual question being asked, nothing else you write matters—your Task Response score will be severely limited.

SOLUTION #1

Master Question Analysis

Before writing a single word, you must complete three essential steps that will determine the success of your entire essay.

1

Identify the Question Type

Recognise whether it's opinion, discussion, problem-solution, advantages-disadvantages, or two-part.

2

Underline Key Parts

Mark the instruction words and specific focus areas that define your task.

3

Decide Your Approach

Determine exactly what you're being asked to do before planning your response.

Question Types Determine Everything

The question type fundamentally shapes your entire approach, structure, and content. Understanding this distinction is crucial:

- Is it asking for your opinion specifically?
- Do you need to present both sides of an argument?
- Should you identify problems and propose solutions?
- Are you evaluating advantages and disadvantages?
- Must you address two separate questions?

Each type demands a different structural approach and content focus.

Problem #2: Poor Essay Structure

Many candidates either lack any clear structure whatsoever, or they attempt to implement complicated frameworks found online that don't actually function effectively in exam conditions.

Your essay requires a clear, logical structure that the examiner can follow effortlessly. This means having the right components in the right places, with appropriate content in each section.

SOLUTION #2

Use a Simple, Reliable Structure

Stop searching for complicated structures. What consistently works is straightforward and proven.

Introduction

Paraphrase the question and briefly state your answer or position.

Main Body Paragraph 1

Present your first main idea and develop it fully with explanation and example.

Main Body Paragraph 2

Present your second main idea and develop it fully with explanation and example.

Conclusion

Summarise your main ideas and clearly restate your answer to the question.

That's the complete structure. Don't overcomplicate it.

Problem #3: Weak Paragraph Development

This is the most significant issue—where candidates lose the majority of their marks.

- Students write a main idea, then immediately jump to the next point without properly explaining or supporting the first one. Or they provide examples that don't genuinely support their argument.

Some candidates attempt to include three or four ideas in one paragraph rather than developing a single idea comprehensively. The examiner wants to see depth of development, not superficial breadth.

SOLUTION #3

The Birthday Cake Strategy

Think of paragraph development like decorating a birthday cake. You don't simply slap on icing and call it finished—you build layers deliberately.

The Three Essential Layers

Layer 1: The Cake

Your main idea—the foundation of everything that follows.

Layer 2: The Icing

Your explanation of why that idea matters, how it connects, what the implications are.

Layer 3: The Decorations

Your specific example or evidence that demonstrates and supports your explanation.

Every paragraph needs all three layers in this order. Most students provide the main idea and example but skip the explanation—or give explanation without a clear example. You need all three components.

Common Development Mistakes

Jumping Too Quickly

Moving to the next main idea before fully developing the current one with proper explanation.

Irrelevant Examples

Providing examples that don't actually support or illustrate the point being made.

Multiple Ideas

Cramming three or four different ideas into one paragraph instead of developing one thoroughly.

Missing Explanation

The most common error—giving main idea and example but omitting the crucial explanation layer.

COMPLETE SYSTEM

The 9-Step Framework

Now let me provide you with the complete process—nine steps that work reliably for any Task 2 question type. This framework has helped hundreds of students achieve Band 7, 8, and even 9.

Steps 1-3: Before You Write

1

Read Carefully

Read the question thoroughly, paying attention to every word and instruction.

2

Identify Question Type

Determine what type of question it is and precisely what it's asking you to do.

3

Plan Two Main Ideas

Plan your two main ideas—and only two main ideas. Don't try to cover everything.

Critical reminder: Don't skip the planning phase. Five minutes of planning will save you fifteen minutes of confused, unfocused writing.

Steps 4-5: Introduction

1

Paraphrase the Question

Rewrite the question in your own words for your opening sentence. Don't copy the exact words—show the examiner you have vocabulary range.

2

State Your Answer

Answer the question briefly in one or two clear sentences. Tell the examiner exactly what your position is.

This isn't the time for explanation—that comes in the body paragraphs. This section is solely for clearly stating your answer or position.

Steps 6-8: Main Body Paragraphs

Step 6: First Main Idea

Begin your first main body paragraph with your first main idea stated clearly in a topic sentence.

Step 7: Explain Thoroughly

Develop that main idea with 2-3 sentences that explain it comprehensively. Tell the reader why this idea matters, how it connects to the question, and what the implications are.

Step 8: Specific Example

Provide a specific example that supports your explanation. Not vague—specific. Not "many people"—tell who, where, when, what happened.

Then repeat Steps 6-8 for your second main body paragraph. Two paragraphs, two main ideas, both fully developed with all three layers.

Where Students Lose Marks in Step 7

Step 7 is where most candidates struggle significantly. They don't explain enough—they state an idea and immediately jump to an example.

Your explanation needs to develop the idea thoroughly:

- Why does this idea matter to the question?
- How does it connect to the broader topic?
- What are the implications or consequences?
- Why should the reader care about this point?

This explanation layer is what demonstrates critical thinking and earns higher band scores. Don't rush past it.

Step 9: Conclusion

Summarise your two main ideas and clearly answer the question one final time.

What not to do:

- Don't introduce new information
- Don't write three long sentences
- Don't simply repeat your introduction word-for-word

Two concise sentences is usually sufficient for an effective conclusion.

Framework Summary

1. **Pre-Writing (Steps 1-3)**
   Analyse question, identify type, plan two main ideas
2. **Introduction (Steps 4-5)**
   Paraphrase question, state your answer
3. **Body Paragraph 1 (Steps 6-8)**
   Main idea, explanation, specific example
4. **Body Paragraph 2 (Steps 6-8)**
   Main idea, explanation, specific example
5. **Conclusion (Step 9)**
   Summarise and clearly answer question

FREE RESOURCES

Option 1: YouTube Video Makeovers

Full-length videos where real student essays undergo complete step-by-step makeovers. You'll see exactly what mistakes students make, why they're losing marks, and how to fix them.

These tutorials are detailed and comprehensive with nothing held back. Every decision is explained, every mistake is analysed, and every improvement is demonstrated.

Perfect for visual learners who want to see the framework in action with real examples.

COMPLETE COURSE

Option 2: Essay Builder Course

All Question Types

Structures specifically designed for every question type you'll encounter in the exam.

Video Lessons

Detailed video lessons for each step of the process with clear demonstrations.

Practice Activities

Structured practice activities that reinforce each component of the framework.

The complete system that takes you through the entire process in comprehensive detail, with everything you need to master Task 2.

Both Resources Show Application

Whether you choose the free YouTube makeovers or invest in the Essay Builder Course, both options will demonstrate how to actually apply what you've learnt today.

You'll see the framework working with real content, real mistakes, and real improvements. This bridges the gap between theory and practice.

The $10 Diagnostic Test

We created this affordable diagnostic specifically to give you clarity on your current level and a personalised roadmap to your target score.

01

You Write One Essay

Using the framework you've just learnt, write one complete Task 2 essay.

02

We Analyse It

Our trained teachers carefully analyse your writing against IELTS criteria.

03

You Get Your Plan

Receive a personalised study plan showing exactly what you need to fix.

What the Diagnostic Reveals

Where You're Losing Marks

Identify specific areas where your writing isn't meeting band requirements.

Hidden Mistakes

Discover errors you're making that you don't even realise are problems.

What to Focus On

Know exactly what to practise first for maximum improvement.

Not generic advice that applies to everyone. Specific feedback on your writing, your mistakes, your priorities.

Why the Diagnostic Matters

Most students waste months practising the wrong things. They repeat the same mistakes because nobody has shown them specifically what's wrong with their writing.

The diagnostic eliminates guesswork. For just $10, you get complete clarity on your current level and a strategic roadmap to your target score.

It's the difference between hoping you're improving and knowing you're improving in the right direction.

YOUR ACTION PLAN

Recommended Next Steps

Review This Framework

Watch this material again if needed. Ensure you understand all nine steps thoroughly.

Download the Structure Guide

Get the written framework document for easy reference whilst practising.

Watch the Makeover Videos

See the framework applied to real student essays with detailed analysis.

Take the Diagnostic

Write one essay and discover exactly where you stand and what to focus on.

That's how you actually improve—not by watching endless random videos, but by getting specific feedback on your specific mistakes and practising strategically.

Welcome to Your IELTS Writing Structures Guide

This guide contains everything you need to master IELTS Writing Task 2 essay structures.

No tricks, no shortcuts—just clear, systematic approaches that work.

What's Inside

Each structure includes:

Colour-coded paragraph breakdowns

Worked examples with real content

Process workflows (Planning → Drafting → Concluding)

Quality checklists for self-evaluation

IELTS ADVANTAGE

How to Use This Guide

01

Choose Your Essay Type

Identify which question type you're working with. Each structure is designed specifically for one essay type—using the wrong structure is one of the most common mistakes students make.

02

Follow the Planning Stage

Don't skip this. The flowcharts show you exactly what to think about before you write. Good planning makes writing faster and easier.

03

Use the Structure

Follow the colour-coded framework. Notice how each paragraph has a clear purpose and every element has its place.

04

Study the Examples

See how the structure works with real content. This shows you what "following the structure" actually looks like in practice.

05

Check Your Work

Use the checklists to evaluate your essays. These help you spot problems before an examiner does.

Important Notes

These structures are templates, not formulas.

You still need to generate your own ideas and use your own language. The structure simply organises your thinking and ensures you include everything examiners expect to see.

Quality over speed.

It's better to write one excellent essay using these structures than to rush through ten mediocre ones. Take time to understand each element.

Practice with real questions.

These structures work because they're based on what IELTS actually tests. Use them with genuine past questions to see real results.

What This Won't Do

This guide won't:

- Write your essays for you
- Replace the need for practice
- Compensate for weak grammar or limited vocabulary
- Guarantee a specific band score

What it will do is give you a proven framework that, when combined with genuine practice and honest self-evaluation, helps you write clearer, better-organised essays that meet IELTS requirements.

Your Next Steps

Save this PDF somewhere you can access easily

Choose one structure and practice it with 3-5 different questions

Master one type before moving to the next

Review the checklists after every practice essay

Now start practising.

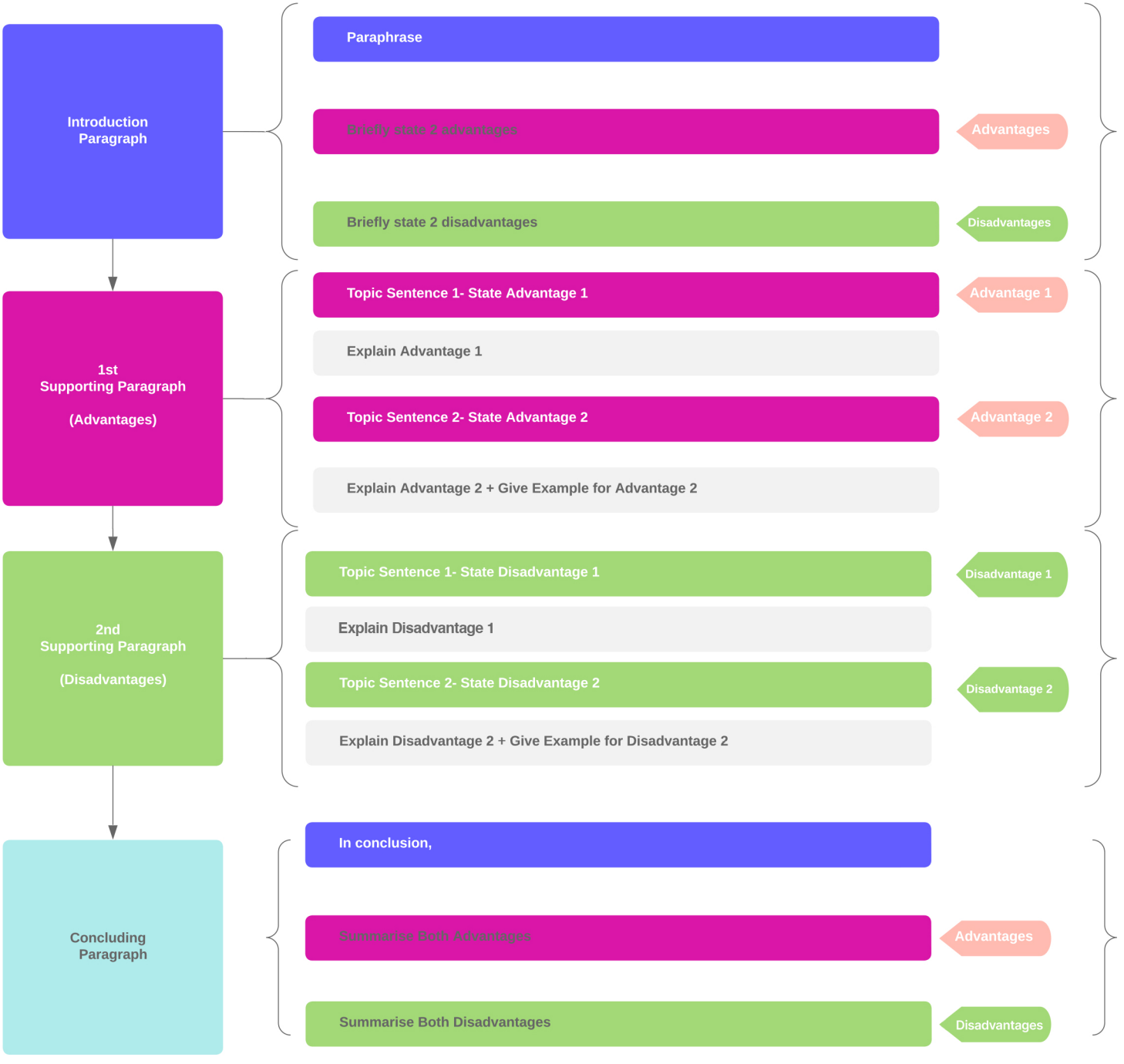
IELTS ADVANTAGE

Questions or need more help?

Visit our **YouTube channel** for video walkthroughs of these structures, or explore our **VIP courses** for comprehensive IELTS preparation with personal feedback.

Advantages and Disadvantages Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Advantages and Disadvantages Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist

In many countries, it is now possible to buy food that has been imported from all over the world.

What are the advantages and disadvantages of this development?

Introduction Paragraph

- Paraphrase
- The availability of products + more markets open for producers. — Advantages
- Carbon emissions + higher prices. — Disadvantages

1st Supporting Paragraph (Advantages)

- The availability of products — Advantage 1
- Can eat fruit all year round because not dependent on climate.
- More markets open for producers. — Advantage 2
- Can sell all over the world e.g. corn in USA.

2nd Supporting Paragraph (Disadvantages)

- Carbon emissions. — Disadvantage 1
- Long distance shipping requires burning of fossil fuels.
- Higher prices — Disadvantage 2
- Shipping costs increase prices e.g. dragon fruit from Vietnam.

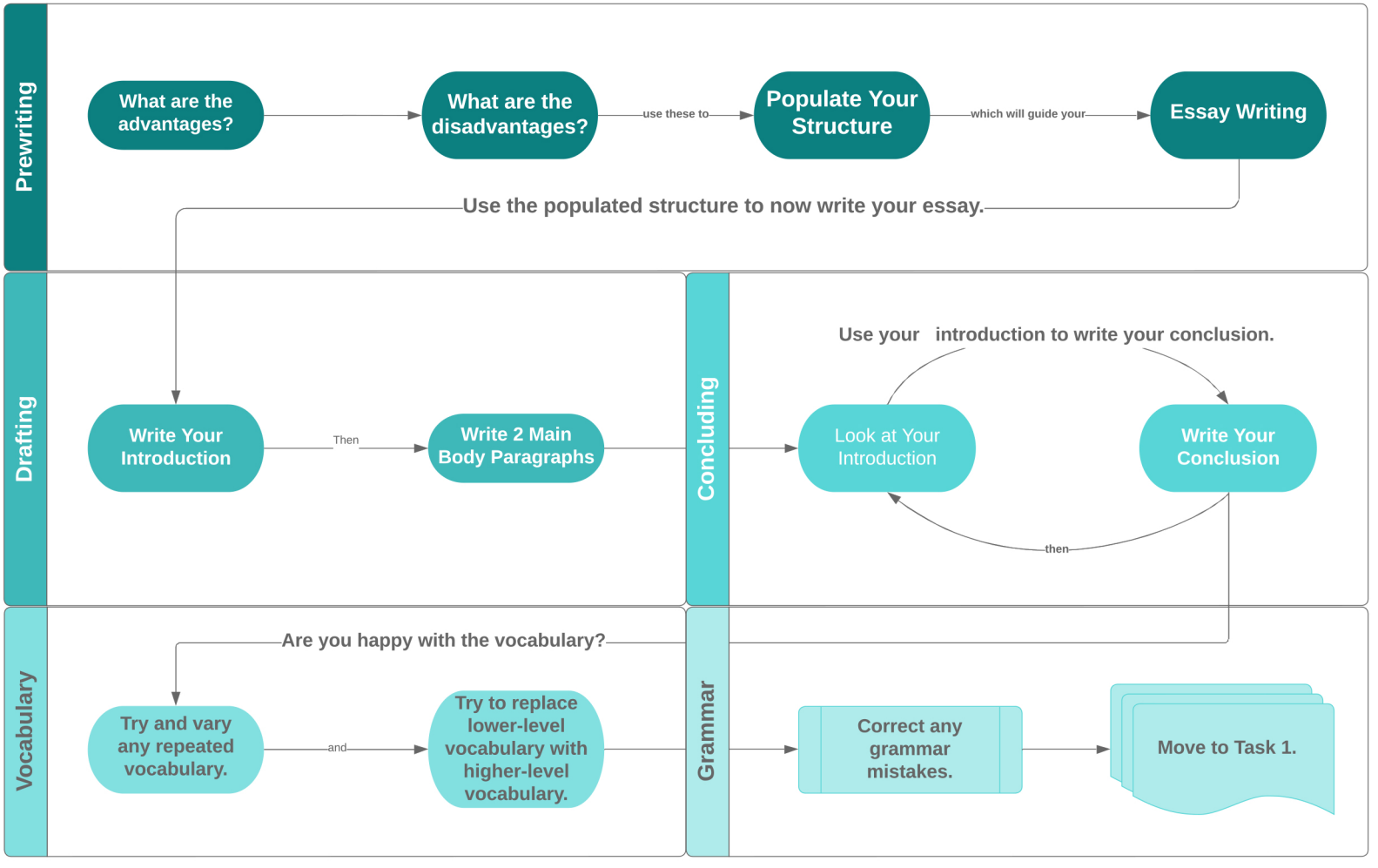
Concluding Paragraph

- In conclusion,
- The availability of products + more markets open for producers. — Advantages
- Carbon emissions + higher prices. — Disadvantages

IELTS ADVANTAGE

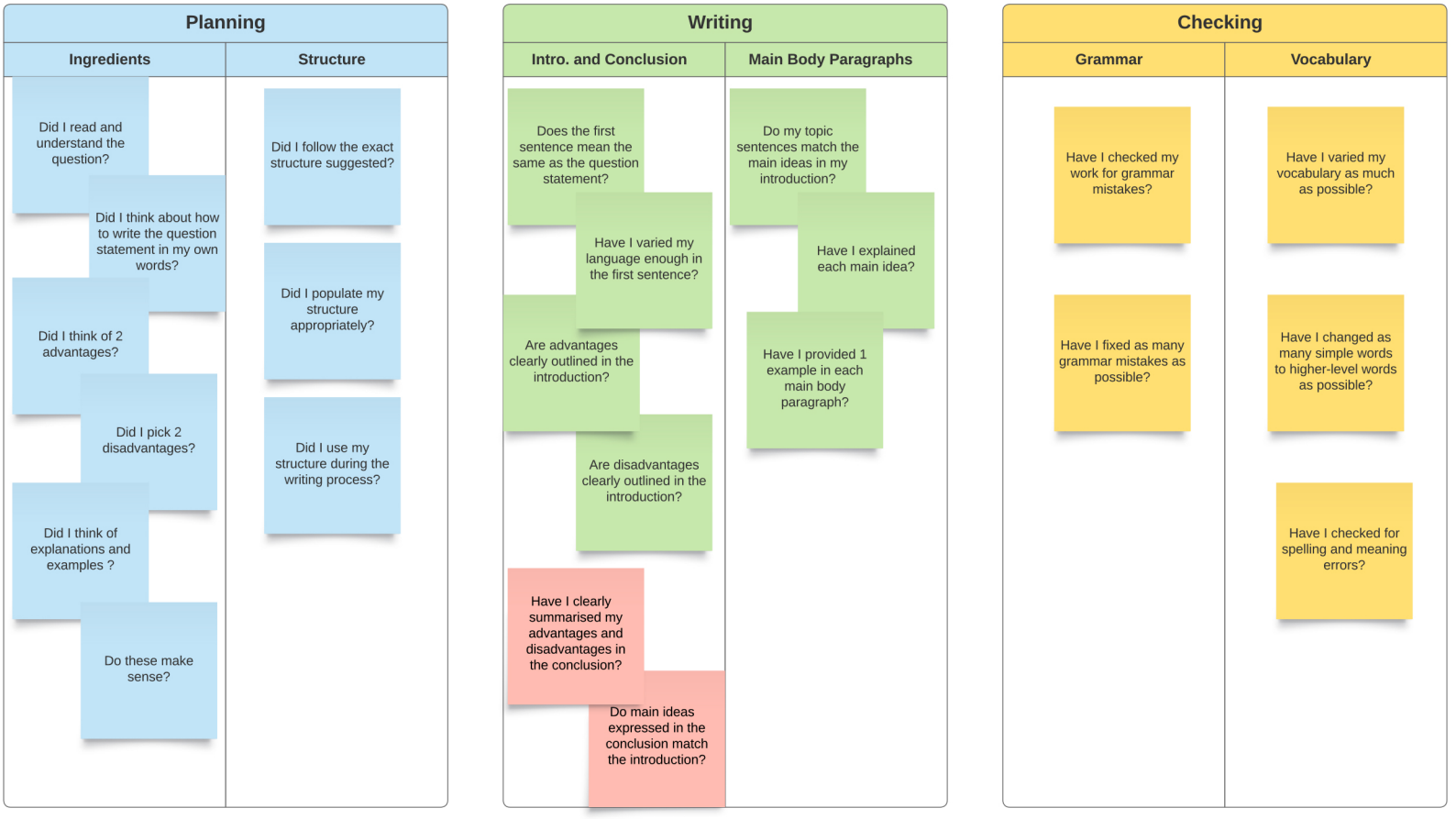
Advantages and Disadvantages Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



Advantages and Disadvantages Essay

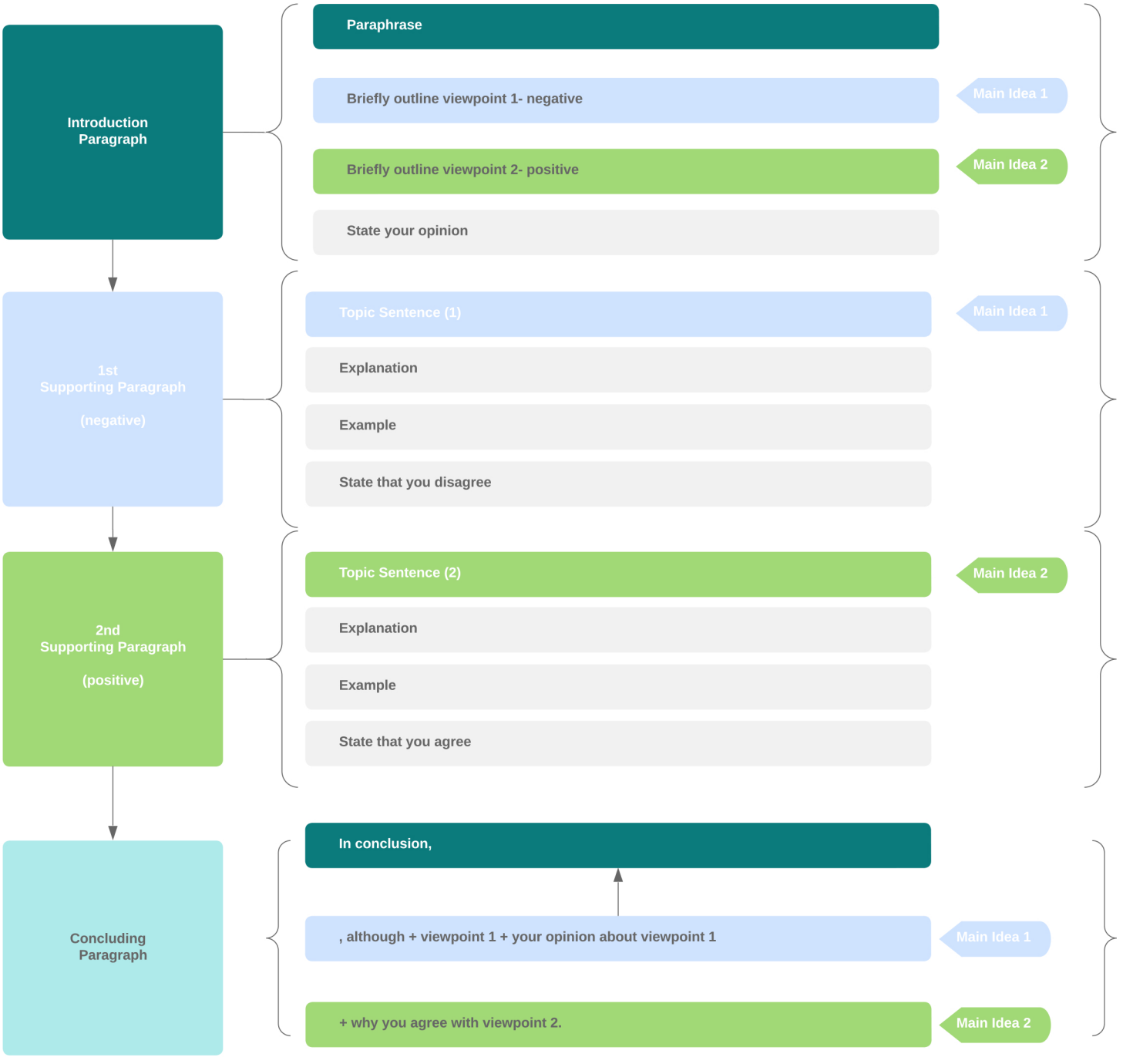
Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Discuss Both Views Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Discuss Both Views Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist

Some think individuals should support themselves after retirement, while others believe the government should be responsible for providing them with financial assistance.

Discuss both views and give your own opinion.

Introduction Paragraph

While some believe governments should provide retired citizens with financial aid, others are of the opinion that retirees should make provisions for themselves.

Promotes a culture of hard work in society — Main Idea 1

More equal — Main Idea 2

I agree that govt should do it because it is fairer

1st Supporting Paragraph (negative)

Promotes a culture of hard work in society. — Main Idea 1

If people know they have no help, they will have to work harder.

United States

Disagree because hard work does not always lead to more money.

2nd Supporting Paragraph (positive)

More equal — Main Idea 2

The majority of people do not have high-paying jobs.

UK

Agree because it's fair.

Concluding Paragraph

In conclusion,

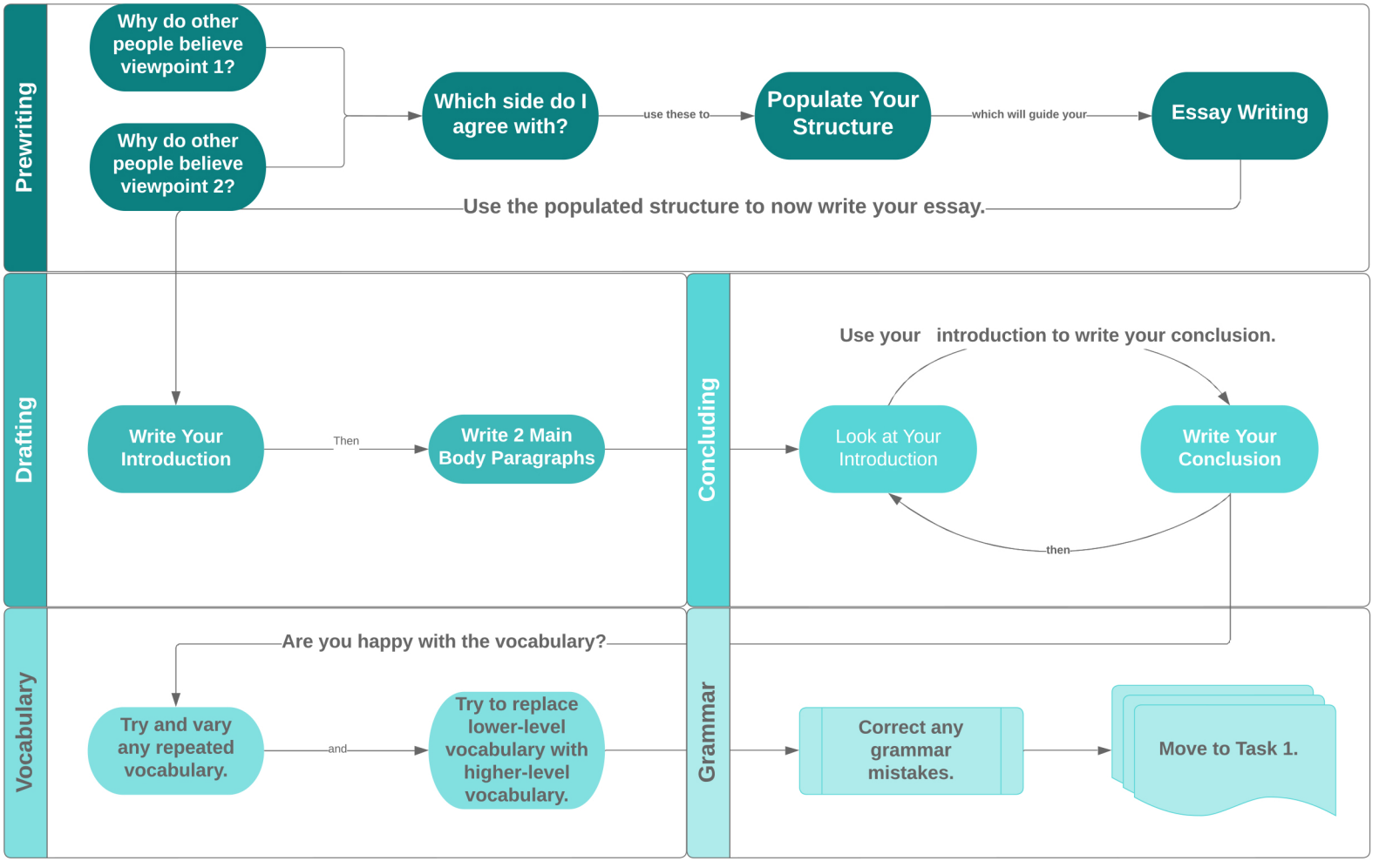
, although it may make some people work harder, hard work doesn't ensure wealth — Main Idea 1

it's fairer that the govt provides a retirement income for everyone — Main Idea 2

IELTS ADVANTAGE

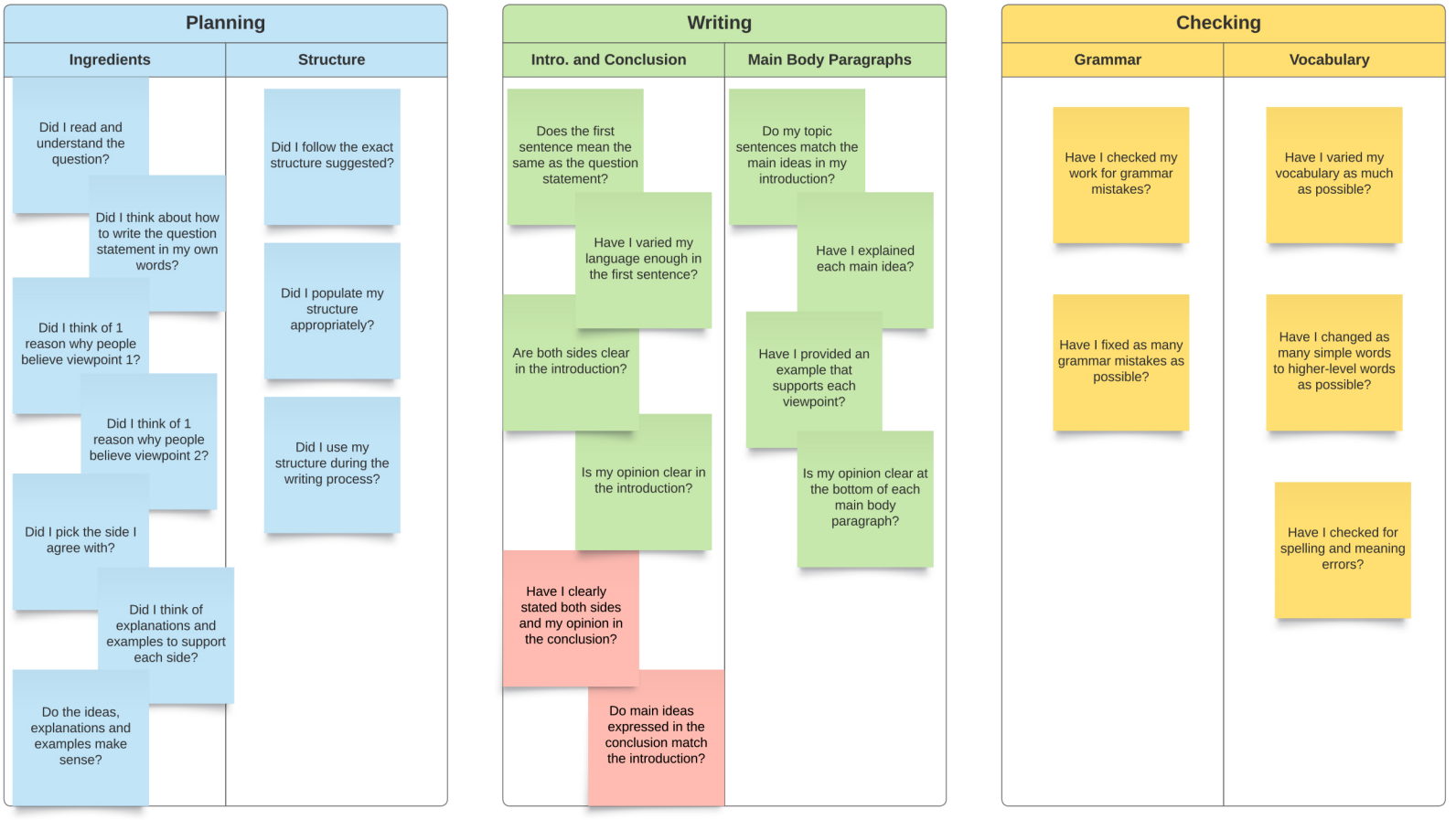
Discuss Both Views Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



Discuss Both Views Essay

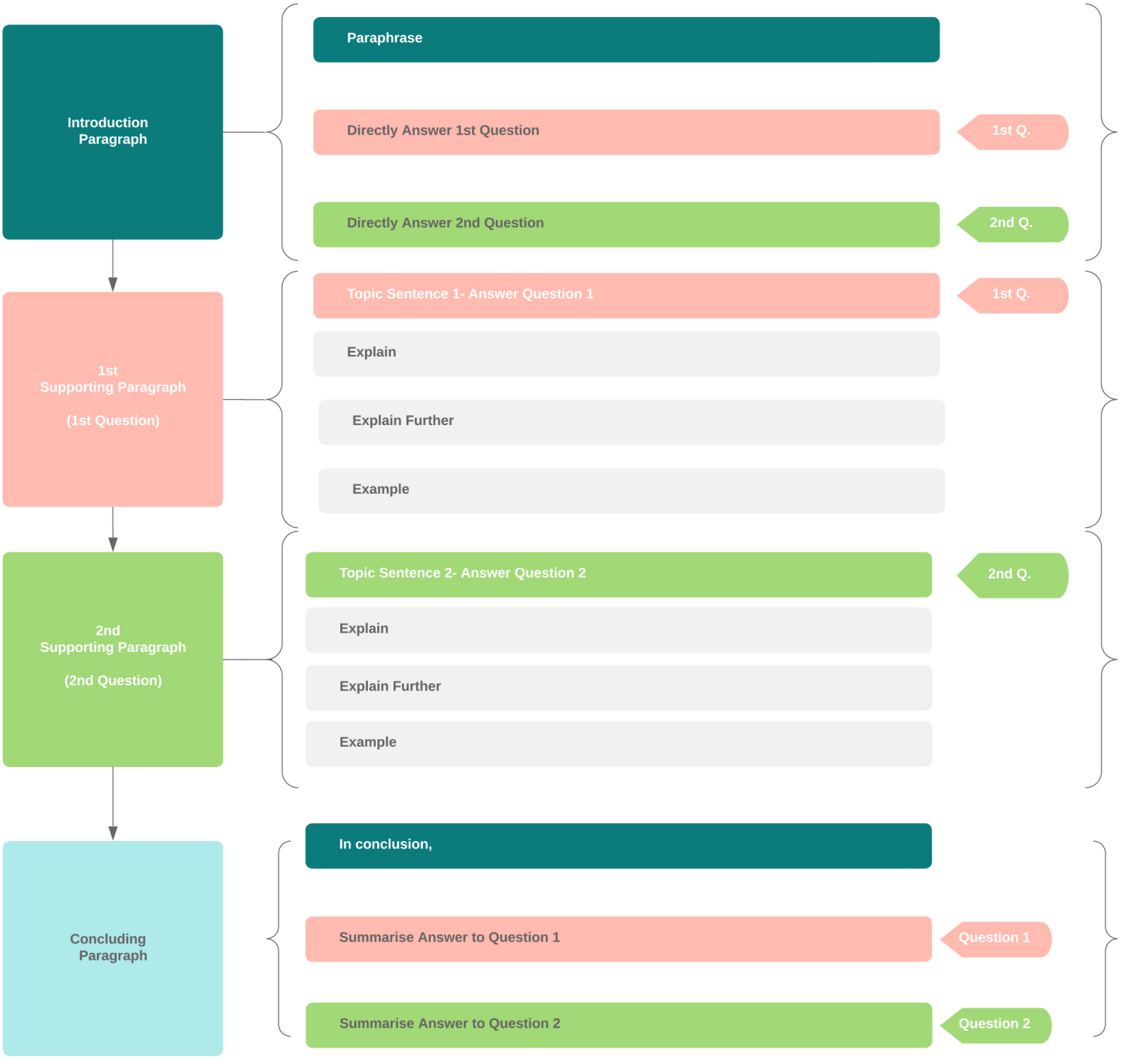
Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Two-Part/Double Question Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Two-Part/Double Question Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist

In some countries, an increasing number of people are choosing not to have children.

Why do you think this is happening?
Is this a positive or negative development?

Introduction Paragraph

- Paraphrase
- Prepare for retirement. — 1st Q.
- Positive because do not feel guilt. — 2nd Q.

1st Supporting Paragraph (1st Question)

- Topic Sentence 1- Prepare for retirement. — 1st Q.
- In the past it was financially viable to have children and prepare for retirement.
- Living expenses have now increased.
- UK increased retirement age.

2nd Supporting Paragraph (2nd Question)

- Topic Sentence 2- Positive- Do not feel guilt. — 2nd Q.
- Many people feel pressure from family and society.
- Now people accept this as a pragmatic decision.
- Single mothers in western countries.

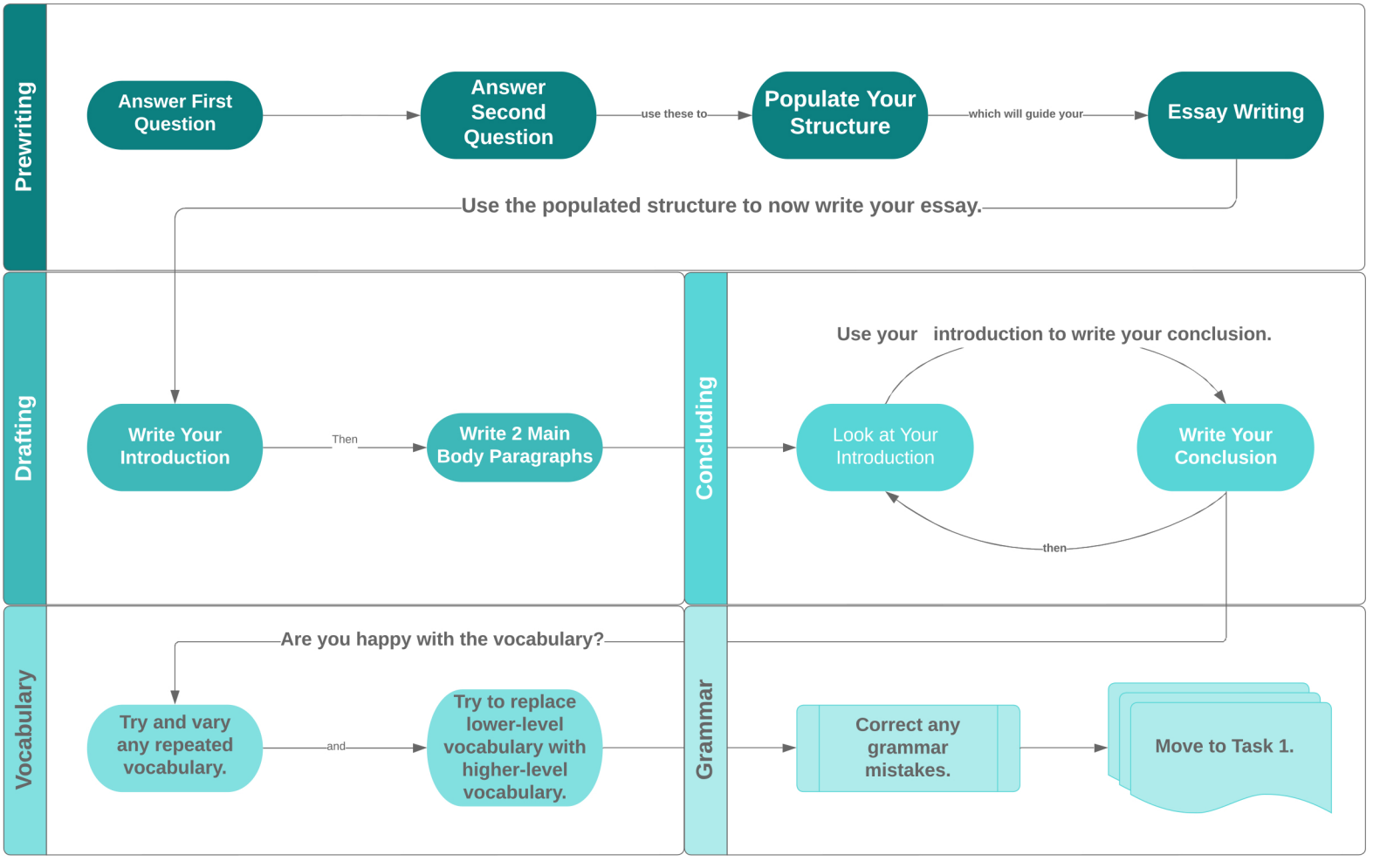
Concluding Paragraph

- In conclusion,
- Prepare for retirement. — Question 1
- Positive- Do not feel guilty. — Question 2

IELTS ADVANTAGE

Two-Part/Double Question Essay

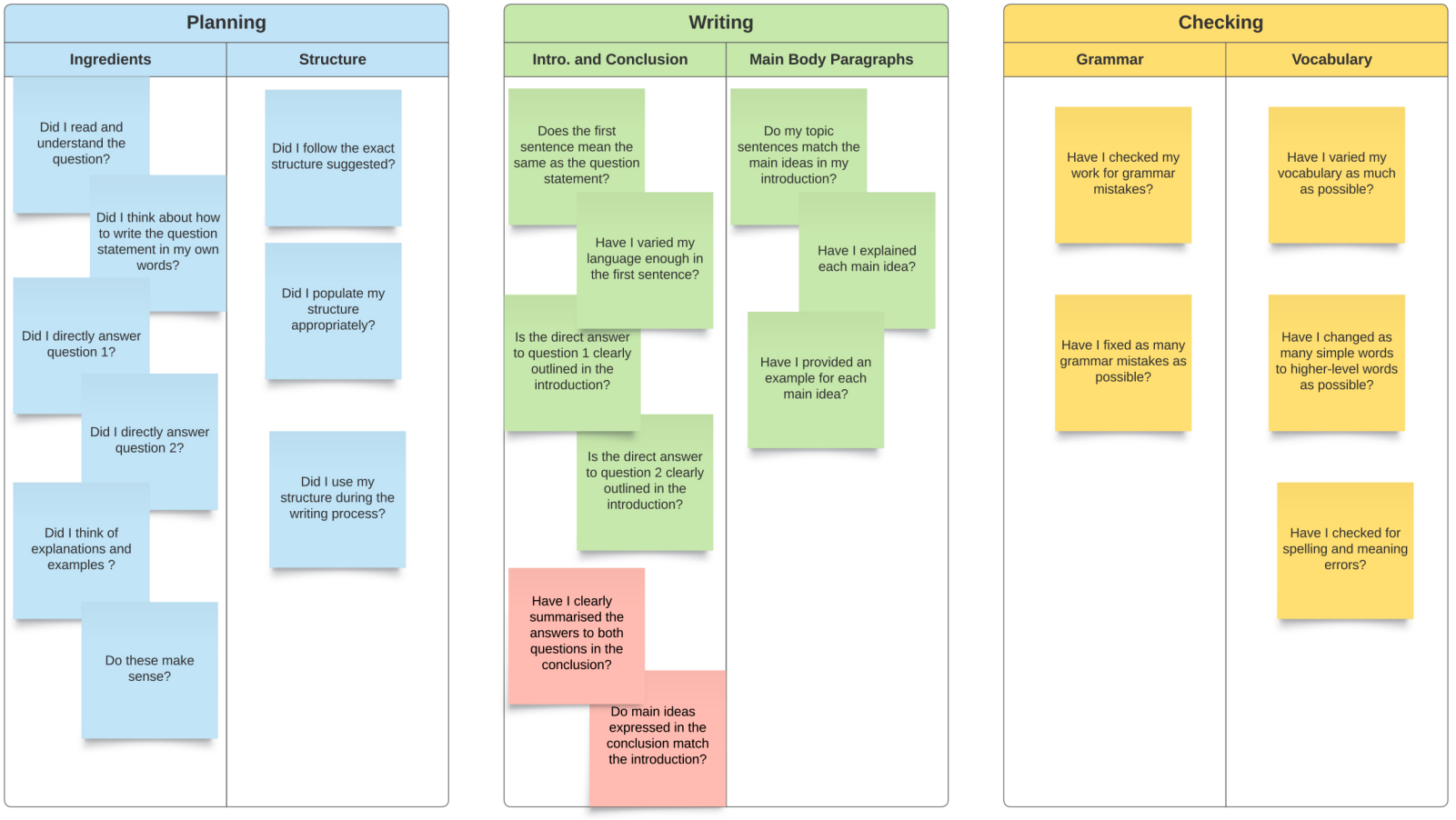
Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Two-Part/Double Question Essay

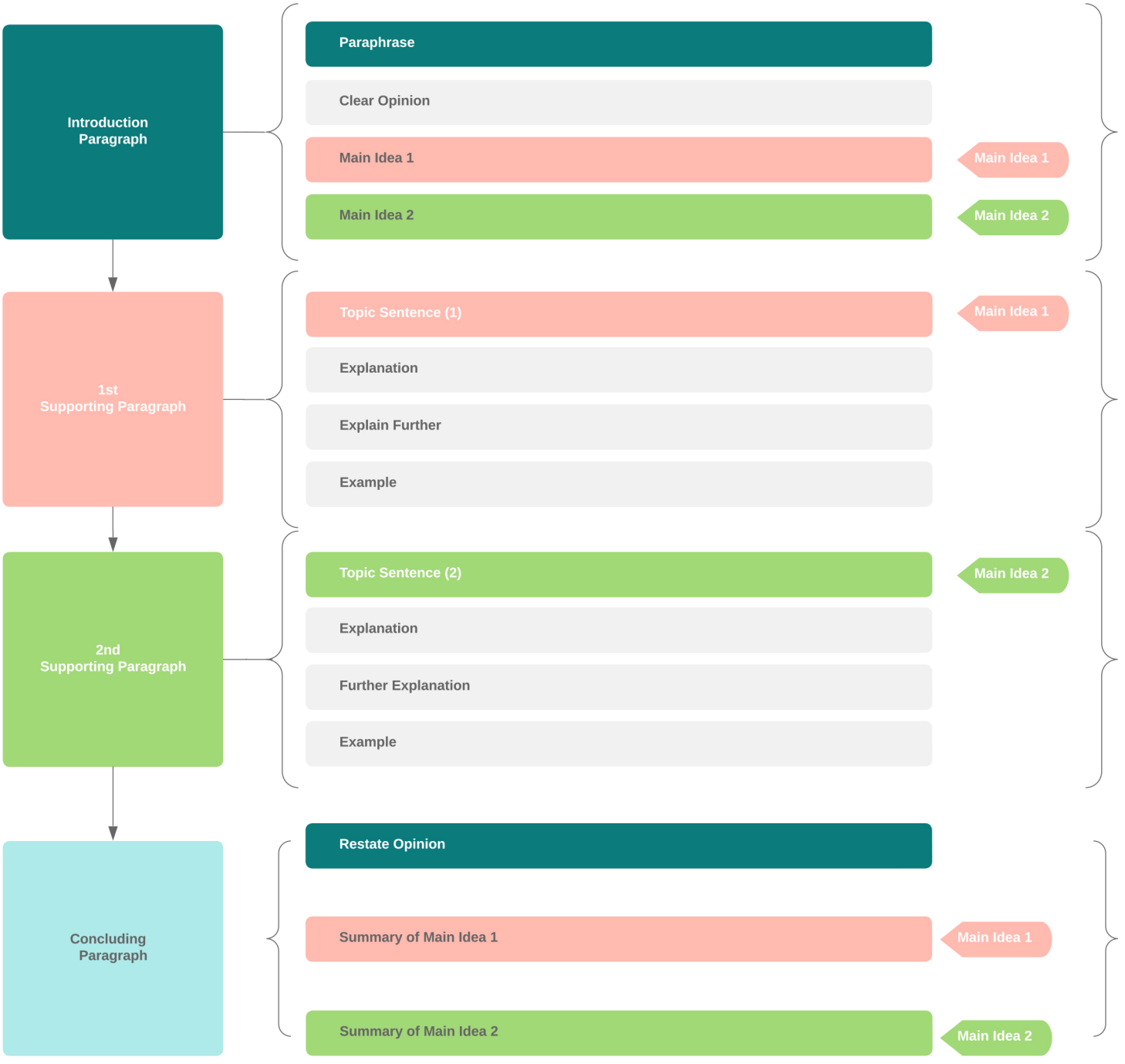
Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Opinion Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Opinion Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist

Question- Some people say that music is a good way of bringing people of different cultures and ages together.

Do you agree or disagree?

Introduction Paragraph

- It is often claimed that music is an effective means of uniting those of varying backgrounds and age ranges together.
- I agree.
- Shared interests. — Main Idea 1
- Can teach other people about your culture. — Main Idea 2

1st Supporting Paragraph

- People from many different countries are fans of the same artists. — Main Idea 1
- This gives people something in common.
- Despite differences, they will have something they both love and will bond over this.
- K-Pop being popular in many different countries.

2nd Supporting Paragraph

- When you meet someone new, you can teach them about your culture through music. — Main Idea 2
- Each country has a unique musical heritage.
- It is very interesting to learn about different types of music and this brings people together.
- Ireland has a unique style of music, instruments and language.

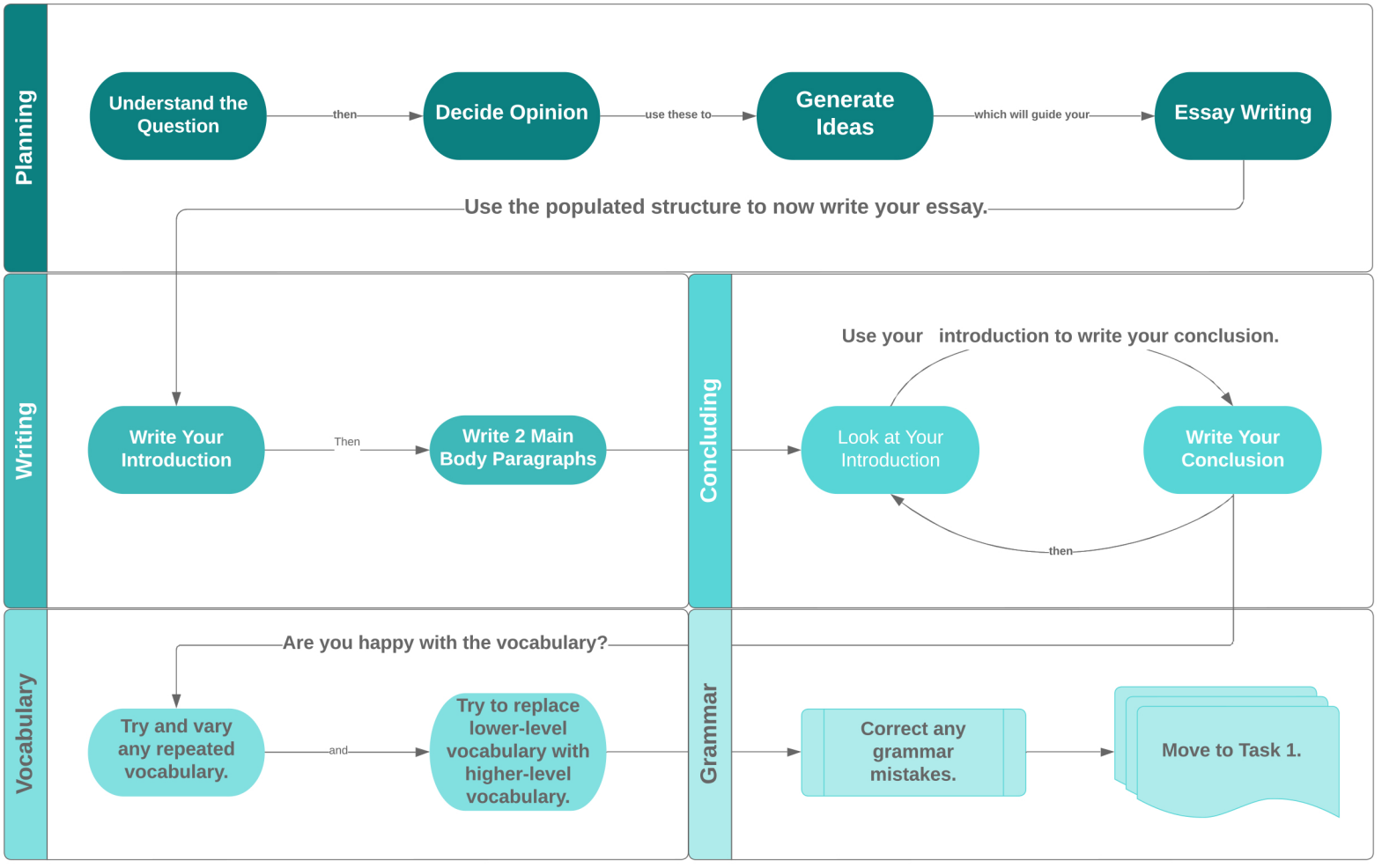
Concluding Paragraph

- I agree with this because.....
- Commonalities. — Main Idea 1
- Teaching about unique musical culture. — Main Idea 2

IELTS ADVANTAGE

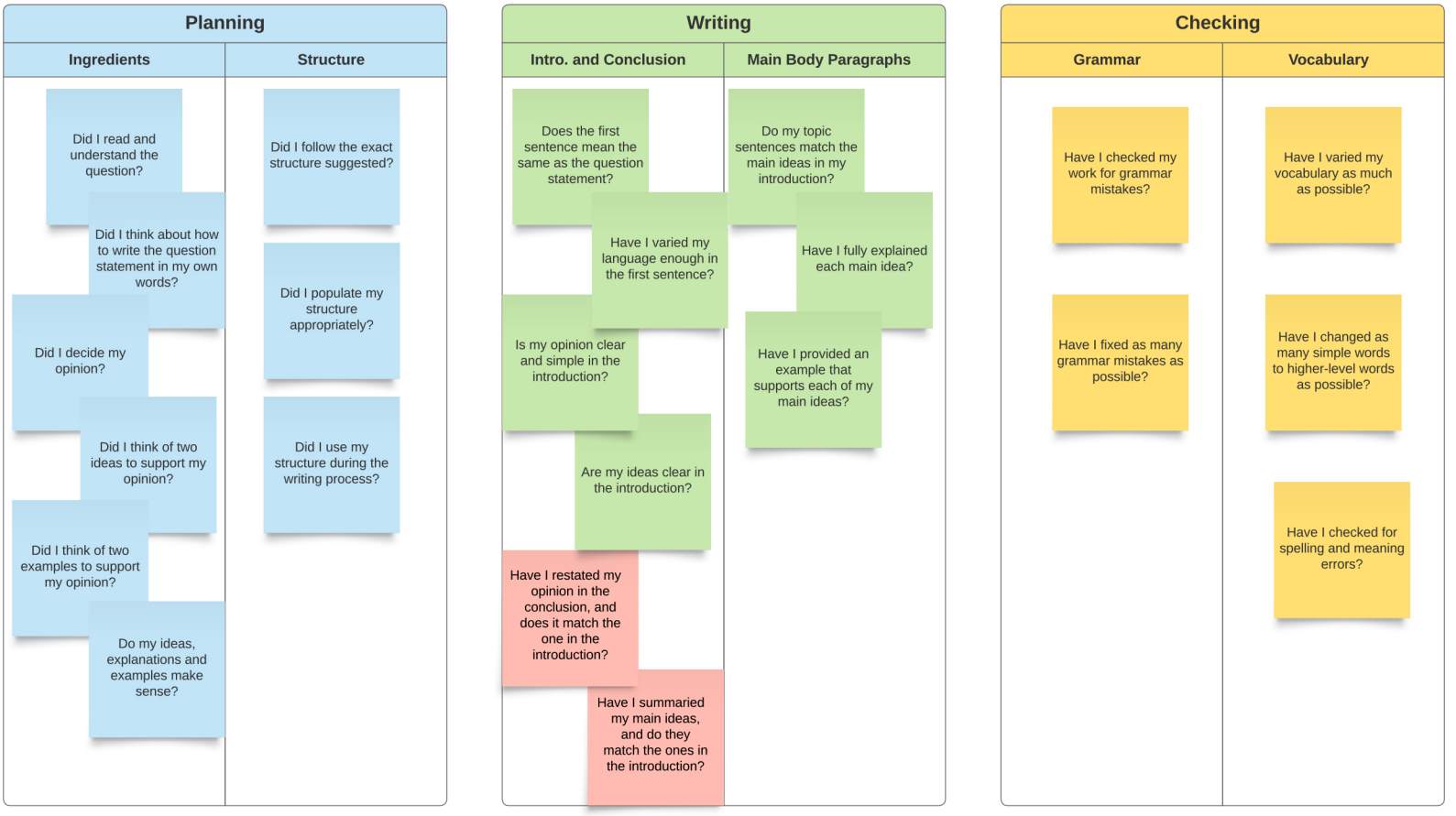
Opinion Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



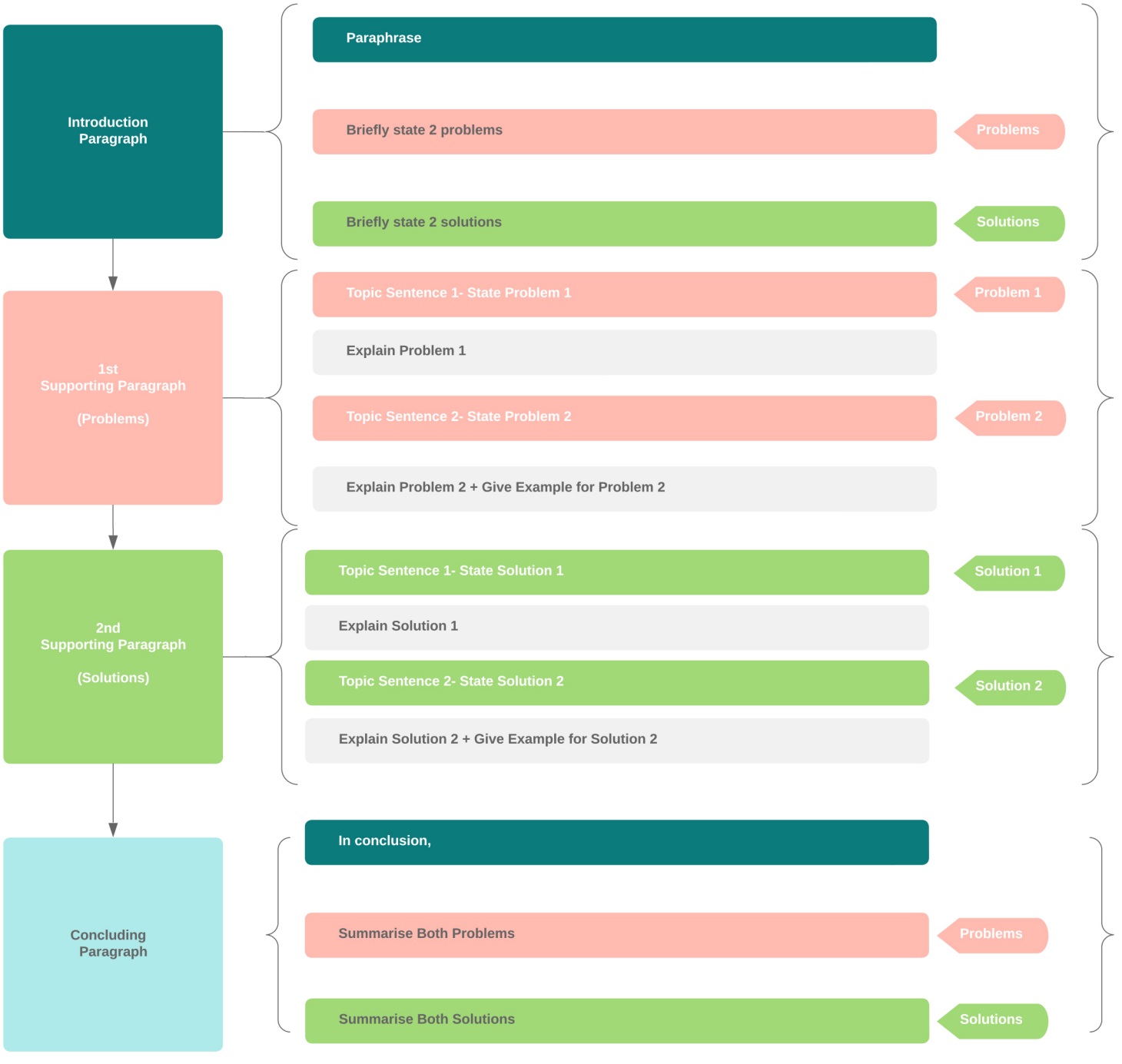
Opinion Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



Problem and Solution Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

Problem and Solution Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist

More and more people are buying products online.

What problems are associated with this, and what are some possible solutions?

Introduction Paragraph

- Paraphrase
- Increase in credit card fraud and low-quality products. — Problems
- Improve online security and transparent customer complaints. — Solutions

1st Supporting Paragraph (Problems)

- Increase in credit card fraud. — Problem 1
- Online shopping requires the use of credit cards which can be targeted by criminals.
- Some online shops sell fake products. — Problem 2
- Easy to trick people online by showing fake items e.g. luxury handbags.

2nd Supporting Paragraph (Solutions)

- Improve cyber security. — Solution 1
- Third party verification.
- Publish real customer complaints on website. — Solution 2
- This will alert new customers to problems e.g. 5 star rating system.

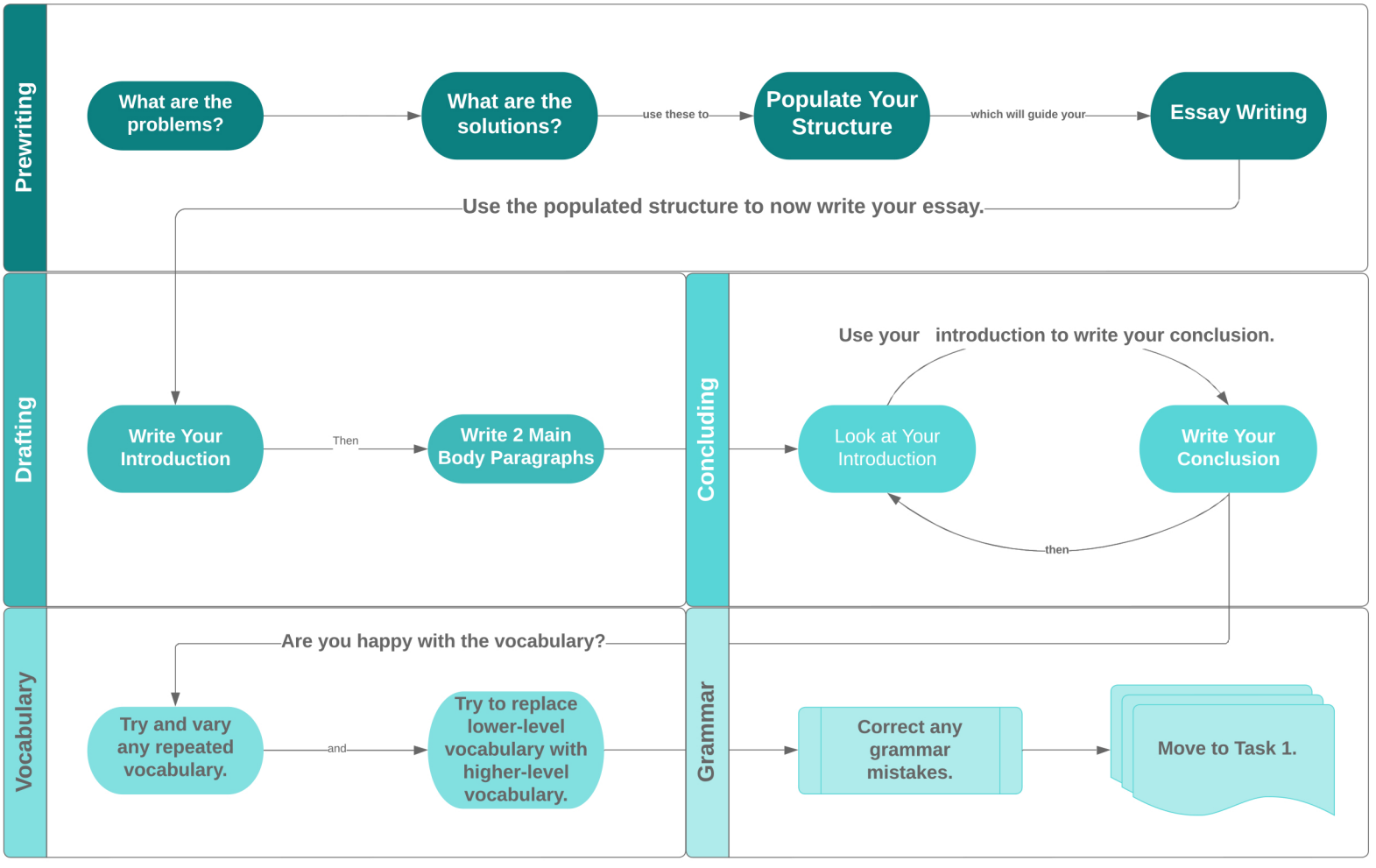
Concluding Paragraph

- In conclusion,
- Increase in credit card fraud and low-quality products. — Problems
- Improve online security and transparent customer complaints. — Solutions

IELTS ADVANTAGE

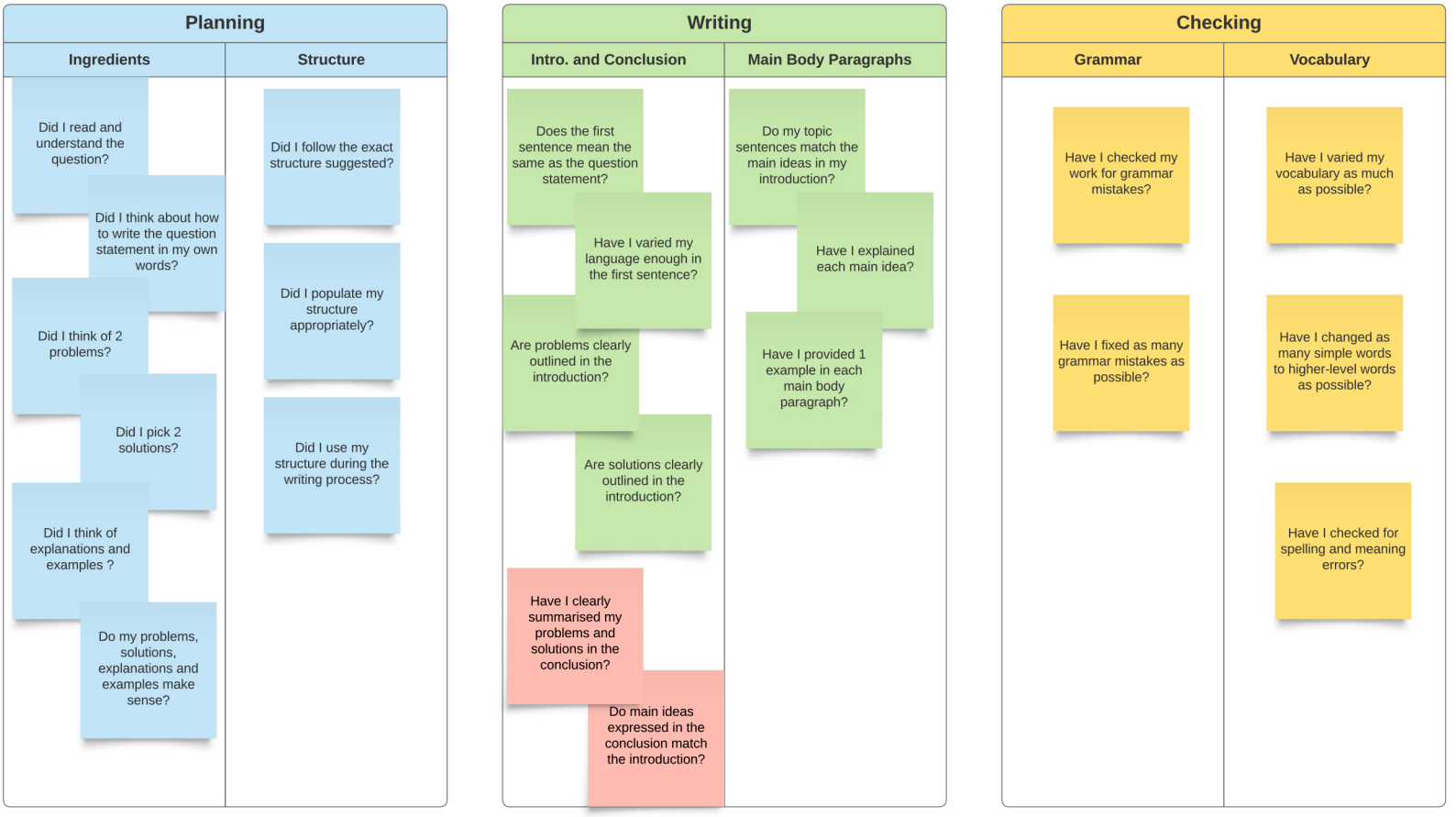
Problem and Solution Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



Problem and Solution Essay

Blank Structure > Populated Structure > Flowchart > Checklist



IELTS ADVANTAGE

IELTS VOCABULARY

IMPROVEMENT PLAN

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3 Step Process

01

Read and Listen

Studies have shown that the number one way for learners to improve their vocabulary is through reading and listening to genuine sources of English.

02

Record

You must record any new words you hear or read. There are lots of ways to do this, so that you will remember them effectively.

03

Review

It is essential that you regularly review these new words and phrases in order to retain them in your memory.

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Reading

Don’t read long lists of boring words.

Read something you are passionate about.

You will learn more effectively if you enjoy the topic you are reading.

Spot new words or phrases

When you see a new word or phrase, underline it or write it down.

Guess

Guess what the words mean before writing them down in your notebook.

Use free resources

There are millions of free blogs, websites, news sites, and eBooks for you to choose from. See my guide at the end.

Read every day

Make reading in English part of your daily routine and you will soon improve.

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Listen

Listen to something you love

Just like reading, you will learn much more if you listen to something you enjoy. If you like football, listen to football commentary or shows. If you like fashion, listen to a podcast about the latest trends. When you hear a new word or phrase, write it down.

Use Free Resources

YouTube has billions of hours of clips for you to listen to. Simply search for things you are interested in and listen. Podcasts are also a great way to improve your vocabulary and listening skills. Again, they are free. These are just a couple of examples from many.

Listen on the go

Put your ear buds in and listen to your favourite Podcast while you walk, work out, travel or work. The possibilities are endless.

There will always be time for you to listen. You can then write down your new words or phrases when you get home.

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Record

A complete book of new words and phrases

Soon you will have a huge number of new words and phrases that will become part of your vocabulary.

Buy a notebook

It does not need to be an expensive notebook. Anything that allows you to record lots of new words or phrases is good.

Use your phone

There are a huge number of apps, like Memrise, that allow you to record lists.

Add things to help you remember

Don't just write the meaning. You can write collocations, synonyms, antonyms, pronunciation, example sentences, pictures etc.

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Review

Do it regularly

One week, two weeks and one month after you first learn a new word should be enough.

Make it fun

There are many word games that you can play on Memrise or Quizlet. You can also get creative and tell stories with your new words.

Use them

Try to use your new words in the same way you would in the speaking or writing tests. You can include them in your answers when appropriate to do so.

Make it part of your routine

It is much more effective to review your new words for 5-10 minutes per day than to leave it all until the day before your test.

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Online Resources

It's all free!

You do not need to spend any money to improve your vocabulary. All of the resources you need are freely available on the internet.

Here is a list of my favourite sites, but there are millions more that will help you. Simply use Google to find something that interests you.

BBC News

All of the common IELTS topics are covered on a daily basis. Listen or read.

YouTube

An endless supply of videos.

Memrise

Nice app for recording and reviewing vocabulary. Makes reviewing vocab fun.

The Guardian

They have a great selection of news articles and podcasts.

Ted Talks

Fun and interesting talks by some of the world's leading thinkers.

eBooks

Hundreds of thousands of books are now available to read online for free.

Stitcher

This app gives you access to hundreds of thousands of podcasts.

Quizlet

Simple tools for learning anything.

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Thank You!

If you have any questions about IELTS or help you in any way, please feel free to get in touch with us via the email below. chris@ieltsadvantage.com

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